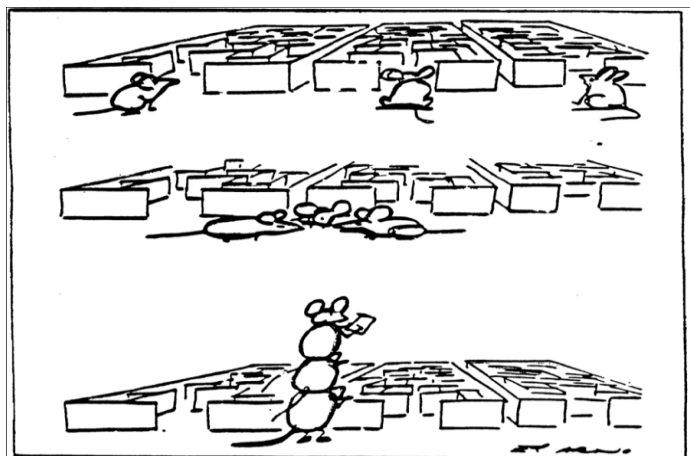

Two (Or More) Heads Are Better Than One

Adventures in leading group learning: a facilitator storybook



The Peer-Assisted Learning Program
SMART Learning Commons
University of Minnesota – Twin Cities

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Foreword by Mary Lilly

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Foreword

As coordinator, supervisor, and trainer of the Peer-Assisted Learning (PAL) program for the past three years, I have observed dozens of undergraduate facilitators making productive learning happen with a roomful of their peers in social and informal environments of their creation. They do it with remarkable enthusiasm and confidence, and with a firm commitment to the principles of peer-assisted learning developed by Dr. David Arendale. The PAL program at our institution is based on the best practices of other national models of peer learning, such as Supplemental Instruction, Emerging Scholars Program, and Peer-led Team Learning, to name a few.

PAL at the University of Minnesota supports historically challenging courses. In some courses, attendance at PAL sessions is completely voluntary; in others, it is required. More often, PAL on our campus resembles the Structured Learning Assistance (SLA) model, in that PAL sessions are automatically placed into the students' schedules when they register. However, unlike SLA, where students attend only up through the first exam if they score well, attendance is expected the entire semester, regardless of grade, and sometimes with points attached. In these cases, PAL at our campus supports particular cohorts of students rather than targeted courses.

Highlighting attendance is important because, as facilitators can affirm, the reason a student comes to PAL can significantly impact his/her attitude and behavior during the session. I am continually amazed by these talented leaders who put themselves on the line under conditions not of their design, and sometimes ones that are less than optimal. They act as

model students, sharing their study strategies and behaviors. They allow their credibility and character to be tested week after week because they truly have a desire to help others. Certainly there are less intimidating ways to earn a paycheck.

This book is a collaborative effort; I share with Lana, the editor, the hope that the stories in it will stimulate all sorts of discussion in the training and professional development of students in similar roles, whether it be conversations about the pedagogy of peer cooperative learning or furthering practical facilitation skills so they can be both competent and confident. I imagine that other program coordinators and those designing pre-semester workshops will use our experiences to generate their own wisdom and policies.

In response to some of the revelations in the stories about my own practices, I admit that I should not have visually reacted to anything that the facilitator – Amanda (p. 121) – did when I observed her PAL session; I was guilty of simply not thinking. And yes, I hired a student who hadn't taken the course, but my reasons are defensible and I would do it again – with the right facilitator, which Harrison was in that situation. However, in future trainings, we will talk about what and what not to reveal to students, as he so astutely recounted in his story (p. 140).

So, in the spirit of peer-assisted learning, we share our experiences with great enthusiasm. As case-stories, they are simultaneously authentic and reflective; instructional, but not prescriptive. Use them as you see fit. How you do so is of interest to us and we welcome your comments. Thank you for reading and be in touch.

Mary Lilly

Preface

The Origin and Goals of the Facilitator Storybook

The fall of 2009 presented me with the challenge of brainstorming a thesis topic for my honors requirement to graduate from the University of Minnesota with a professional journalism degree. While this is standard procedure for honors students, I found myself uninspired and filled with dread. As I have worked to complete my undergraduate degree, I have questioned whether “traditional” journalism (reporting, writing, or editing for a print publication) is really what I want to focus my life’s work around. With this uncertainty brooding, I was coming up short for a thesis topic that would interest and engage me for a lengthy number of pages.

Around the same time I was struggling to find a topic I was passionate about, my boss and U of MN’s Peer-Assisted Learning (PAL) Program Coordinator, Mary Lilly, mentioned an idea that she had been tossing around. She wanted to produce a new guide for the purpose of training first-time PAL facilitators. She imagined a handbook – a conversational, light guide to the successful facilitation of PAL sessions. Upon hearing my thesis frustration, she asked if I wanted to work directly with her to take this idea and make it into something tangible. Of course I would! Would it qualify for a thesis project? It turns out that it did.

The project pitch was just what I needed to rejuvenate my sense of purpose in my studies. While I couldn’t reach a summa level honors award by completing a project as opposed to a thesis paper, it was the preferable option to sacrifice that title in order to work on something I cared about. *This* was a

topic I had developed a passion for over my three years of exposure to it as a PAL facilitator. In fact, PAL had provided me with inspirations for previous journalism assignments as well. As a sophomore in a business writing course, I created a feasibility report detailing the changes that administrators could implement to get the most out of PAL. In my magazine writing course, I wrote my final feature on how educators can identify learning styles and adapt their class structure to their students, similar to what PAL facilitators are trained to do. I found myself wanting to work with the program – understanding it and bettering it – at every chance I could get.

Personal drive aside, however, I knew that the facilitator handbook was something our program could use. The literature available for training purposes is heavily data-driven and often dry. While the information is all there, it is hardly engaging. For the first year of U of M's PAL training in 2007, our program used this type of manual. I was in the first batch of facilitators that year, and though I learned an abundance about peer-assisted learning, I can testify on behalf of my coworkers and myself that many of us did not feel confident walking out of our first training sessions. Perhaps, even more so, we did not feel confident walking *into* our first facilitating sessions the next week.

The past two years, however, Mary and other administrative staff have designed the trainings themselves, presenting the information in a way that emulates how a PAL session is conducted with students. Experienced facilitators sit in groups with new facilitators. Groups work as teams on an activity and then share their findings with the rest of the training

session. Some content is even learned by way of games and competition.

Just as this design of training embodies what PAL is, creating a handbook to share our experiences seemed congruent with the design of PAL: peer-to-peer. Countless meetings and deliberations after the project began, the idea of a facilitator handbook evolved into a storybook. What better way to share valuable experiences than through a narrative? Over the course of four months, I sat down with more than 25 facilitators individually and tape-recorded as they recalled their most memorable and meaningful experiences as a facilitator – some humorous, some dreadful and others rewarding.

As you'll notice when you read the stories, many facilitators have reached a new perspective on their previous experiences; they reflect and say, "Looking back, if I had to do it again, I would..." Others, however, present no such amendments or closure; the situation just is.

And that's the way I like it. This storybook isn't meant to instruct or give infallible "how-to" answers. You, as a new facilitator, won't get a good feel for how to facilitate until you actually start experiencing it firsthand. Additionally, the storybook does not aim to replace instructional training materials as the sole method of preparing new facilitators. Rather, we wish to supplement them with by providing some of our facilitators' experiences, real and from the trenches, in hopes that you can relate to them and be made aware of situations you may encounter.

It is also my hope that these stories will be springboards for discussion and tools for critical thinking. Specific stories could be read in small groups in facilitator training. Each group

could then summarize and present their thoughts on the story to the entire training group. Or, if one topic is brought up repeatedly in team meetings throughout the semester, the leader could assign some readings on that topic before the next meeting, when facilitators would then reflect on the stories' implications. Perhaps at its simplest form of use, a facilitator could pick up the storybook the night before their session, flip to the chapter on wielding authority, and find relief in the fact that sometimes being stern is necessary and, in fact, okay. In the end though, it doesn't matter how the storybook is used as long as the facilitator feels a heightened sense of readiness for his or her PAL session after reading a story or two.

Methodology

The facilitators that have contributed to this storybook were either facilitating in the spring of 2010, or had facilitated and left the program for outside reasons (such as graduation or other work) sometime between 2007 and 2010. All of PAL's current and past facilitators have been undergraduate students at the University of Minnesota and were hired because of their subject knowledge, leadership traits and genuine interest in helping others. Each underwent PAL training for every semester they facilitated.

In order to find stories that would be valuable for new facilitators, I conducted a screening process with all of the facilitators, past and present. I emailed this group, which is more than 40 people strong, a set of prompt questions and asked them to think back on their experiences with PAL and respond 'Yes' or 'No' to each prompt question. Prompt questions were categorical and based on topics that had resurfaced frequently in

the three years I was with the program. For example, one prompt question was, “Do you have a story about a time when you felt you lost control of your session?” I noted in the email that these were only the most common topics and that facilitators should not feel limited by them; miscellaneous stories were asked for as well.

More than 20 facilitators responded, and I set up individual interviews with them. In coffee shops, libraries, patios and classrooms, we met – myself, the facilitator and my trusty audio tape recorder. I asked facilitators about each of the stories they had noted; they recalled them freely without interruption. I then transcribed the interviews in full and edited them for repetition and clarity.

It would have been easy to organize the stories based on the prompt question that sparked them; however, I wanted the stories to speak authentically. I didn’t want to nominate the important themes; I wanted the facilitators’ stories to do so. With this in mind, I tagged each story with key concepts, categorizing similar stories together to create skeletal chapters, which were then fleshed out as more stories came in. Although many stories could easily fit in more than one chapter, I’m confident that they speak powerfully in their places, both on their own and as a collective whole with other stories in the same chapter.

Background

We have 30-35 undergraduate facilitators each semester and one full-time program coordinator. There are three teams – math, chemistry and humanities – and each has a team leader, who is an experienced undergrad facilitator, also leading his/her own sessions. Half of the facilitators conduct one session a

week, and the other half (primarily math) conduct two sessions each week. All of us attend one lecture per week and spend two to three hours a week preparing for our sessions.

More often, PAL on our campus resembles the Structured Learning Assistance (SLA) model, in that PAL sessions are automatically placed into the students' schedules when they register. However, unlike SLA, where students attend only up through the first exam if they score well, attendance is expected the entire semester, regardless of grade, and sometimes its with points attached. In these cases, PAL at our campus supports particular cohorts of students rather than targeted courses.

Our PAL program emphasizes reflection, communication and documentation. Facilitators meet on a biweekly basis to support and listen to each other. We share experiences and offer advice, similar to the goal of our storybook. Facilitators are also required to keep electronic records of their experiences by way of a Moodle site. Every other week, facilitators post a reflection of their most recent PAL session. Topics may vary, but often focus on the unforeseen problems or oddities facilitators have encountered. These Moodle postings are available for everyone to read, and become the basis for discussions in team meetings. Some weeks the team leaders will require their members to comment on one or two postings of their choice, to offer on-line feedback and to be supportive of a peer facilitator's decisions. In addition, we maintain an on-line inventory of session plans, worksheets and games that facilitators have prepared for others to "borrow" from when planning future sessions.

We also have been dedicated to continually evaluating our effectiveness. As part of the Office of Undergraduate Education, we measure the correlation between PAL attendance and final course grades, and we continue to report a positive impact of PAL on academic achievement. Facilitators administer mid-semester surveys, which have been designed collectively by the different teams, in each of their PAL sessions, asking for constructive feedback on how they can improve the PAL experience. Facilitators then discuss this feedback with each other and their supervisor, and make the changes they feel are feasible and beneficial. This continual communication and openness with students ensures that our program has the students' best interests at heart.

Our PAL program has benefitted immensely from the experience, scholarship, and on-campus presence of Dr. David Arendale, who was instrumental in the establishment of Supplemental Instruction (SI), the peer-learning model upon which PAL is based. Dr. Arendale has worked in researching and developing this model since the 1970s, and in 2002, he moved from the University of Missouri-Kansas City to the University of Minnesota and began working in the Department of Postsecondary Teaching and Learning. His professional influence has been valuable in molding PAL to reflect the best in cooperative learning pedagogy. Each facilitator takes a semester-long course with Dr. Arendale in their first semester of facilitation to better understand the principles underlying PAL and to interact with other first-time facilitators.

I view myself as an ideal proctor for the task of orchestrating and editing *Two (Or More) Heads Are Better Than One* due to my experience with PAL and my professional

studies. I was part of the first training class of facilitators when the program was installed in September 2007, and I have continued to work with PAL for six out of the eight semesters that I've spent at the U of M. As previously mentioned, I have spent time researching the strategies and effects of peer-learning programs beyond my duties as a facilitator, developing a greater understanding of its principles. Lastly, and perhaps most importantly, I believe in the program's purpose. I have witnessed students' growth, cooperation and success (both personal and academic), and it is a testament to the hard work of the program's staff.

This book has challenged me to think critically about the process of facilitating a college class – a task that has become second nature to me. Stepping back from that role and listening to my fellow facilitators with an outsider's ear has given me great pride and insight into what our program accomplishes. I am grateful that an undergraduate part-time position has allowed me to get my foot in the door of professional writing – and I am proud to have used my skills to contribute to the growth of a program so dedicated to helping students succeed.

Facilitators, you may not know it all, but you were chosen to lead with good reason. Be confident in your sessions and do what feels right. If anyone understands what students are facing, it's you.

Lana Walker
University of Minnesota, Class of 2010
B.A. Professional Journalism

Acknowledgements

The idea for this project percolated for several months, and probably would have remained that way had not an enthusiastic and skilled student embraced it for her senior thesis. Lana Walker has stood out as a model peer-assisted learning (PAL) facilitator since her first semester in this role, over three years ago. When I first arrived, colleagues and faculty advised me to watch Lana in action, as she was the standard to which we wanted to train and develop our undergraduate study group leaders. Not only can she get a group of grumpy college algebra students to laugh, work together in small groups, and share their problem-solving strategies, Lana has shown tremendous skill in creating a unique and very accessible teaching tool. Right from the beginning, Lana knew what purpose this storybook would serve; her description in her preface couldn't be said any better.

I could not have produced the product you hold. Just as the undergraduate status is fundamental to the success of our PAL facilitators, Lana's experience and well-earned respect by her peers has allowed for genuine storytelling in her moveable office. I am grateful for her talent and tenacity in pursuing this storybook.

Our work in the PAL program is continually supported by Lynell Williams who, as Director of the SMART Learning Commons, oversees various academic support programs at the University of Minnesota-Twin Cities. Her trust in our vision has allowed us to be creative and to extend meaningful academic opportunities, such as this one with Lana, to other students preparing for their own careers.

Much appreciation goes to Dr. David Arendale, whose credentials as a respected scholar and authority on learning assistance are well-recognized in the field. He is always generous with his time, his knowledge, and his counsel. How fortunate the world of developmental education and the University of Minnesota are to have his expertise and genuine dedication to the art of learning. He has contributed to our confidence in pursuing this project in so many ways.

Finally, thank you to all the facilitators who so generously contributed their stories and were willing to reflect and tell on themselves. They are the real heroes of this project. Our gratitude goes out to the following past and present U of M PAL facilitators: Jered Bright, Dorothy Cheng, Abby Cole, Shannon Dickey, Michelle Ferkul, Soo Han, Mandy Johnson, Niketa Kataria, Jeff Kerzner, Jeanna Koch, Beth Koeppel, Allison Little, Melissa Lueder, Alicia Rue, Amanda Rydberg, Lauren Sawallisch, Kelley Schreiber, Erin Spoo, Anh Trinh, Harrison Wojcik and Alex Yue.

*Mary Lilly
PAL Coordinator
University of Minnesota, Twin Cities*

Chapter 1: **What's My Role?**

■ You're a facilitator - a student facilitator at that. What does that mean? If you don't know the answer, consider yourself one of the gang! Semester after semester, there is an overarching struggle to understand the limits of our role, and it's not just with new facilitators. Even the most seasoned facilitators are faced with situations that force them to step back, evaluate the situation and their role, and take forward action from there.

■ Chances are, you were chosen for this position because you know the subject matter and have a personality and temperament fit for leadership. But believe it or not, many facilitators find themselves participating in the program again and again because they care, and because the feeling of making a difference is indescribably rewarding. Your initial feelings of nervousness, excitement, annoyance – whatever they may be in your first sessions – will soon be accompanied by a true regard for the well-being of your students.

■ The fact that we begin to care so much can sometimes put us in a tight spot. When students struggle, we want to alleviate their stress. To reassure them, we want to solve their problems - both figuratively and literally. The problem: that's not the role of PAL facilitator. A tutor, maybe. A facilitator, no. Have you ever heard the phrase that the right thing is often the hardest thing to do? It's kind of like that.

■ It's hard to ignore that voice tempting you to give students more help than you should, and it takes time to find the balance between being a helpful resource while still

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- challenging students to think on their own. Lucky for you, we've
- been in your shoes.
-

-Lana

“What I like most about PAL is reaching out and teaching students – for the sake that I want to be a teacher – and knowing that something I did helped them learn. When I understand something and know I can teach it, it's really hard for me to slow down and make it a facilitating opportunity rather than just a teacher-centered class.

So during review days, I'd go through all the chapters, figure out main concepts and either make a Jeopardy board or a review packet. There would be so many problems to do that, in the 50 minutes, the students wouldn't get it done. They'd always want me to go to the board and finish it or do more. Those days, I taught the most.

Even though that's not what we're supposed to do – we should be redirecting questions to the students' peers – it's hard. It's hard to know where you can cross the line and where you can't in regard to how we're supposed to help as a PAL facilitator. All in all, I strived for the majority of the class to be peer-on-peer, using a combination of individual work, group work and whole-class work. Then, if people still didn't get it, I'd put in my two cents. On review days though, it was a special exception because there were so many more problems. Usually we would do 10 problems, but on review days, there'd be 30.

I remember talking to other facilitators who said they would do two or three problems, and that was it. They would work the whole 50 minutes on those two or three questions. I

don't know how they do it, but to elaborate and talk and discuss about that for 50 minutes, in my opinion, would be a waste of a class. As a student, all I'm getting out of it is two or three problems. By doing it that way, it's definitely more "facilitator," but everyone says that to learn math, you have to use repetition. You have to practice. You need to keep doing it over and over, so with that in mind, it was hard to limit the session to just a couple problems.

-MANDY

"The students I work with this semester are the same ones I had last semester. They requested that a new section of PAL be made for the next course they were moving up to. We went to the professor and asked her if she'd be okay with that. At first, she said 'no' because she didn't quite understand the program and thought I would try to be a TA and actually teach the students.

Eventually she started to come around, and I had a meeting with her. The first thing she said was, "This is my material, and I don't want you teaching it." I told her not to worry, that I wasn't there to do that at all. I just had to explain to her what the point of PAL was.

After that, she was very helpful and would ask if I had any announcements at the beginning of lectures.

-BETH

"Students know that my role is sort-of a teacher; that's why they come. I can see that. Every time a student goes over a problem or a group presents a problem, the class looks at me. I have to train

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them to learn from each other. I will ask the person who's presenting to ask the class, "Do you have any questions?" You have to shift the power gradually to students over the semester, so they can see that they can learn from each other. Other people in the session are just as smart as the facilitator. It's a progressive change throughout the semester.

-ALEX

"Last semester, my students in my sessions had a new professor. He was a grad student, and he was just terrible. He taught them the wrong things, using methods they didn't know yet. So my students would come to class and ask me, "How do you take the limit of this?" I'm like, "You aren't supposed to know this yet. I didn't learn that until the class after this. You still have a class to go."

The whole semester was difficult for me because I felt like I was teaching instead of just facilitating. I would bring in a game and they wouldn't fail per se, but they needed a lot of explanation of the math topics behind the games. They didn't seem to be able to learn by just using their books; they needed explanations. I would teach them all the little tricks I knew and they still wouldn't get it.

There were also times that I was frustrated with the teacher because I would email him a question and, in two weeks, I still wouldn't have a response. When I went to his office hours, he was never there. It got really hard for me to listen and respond to my students' complaints when I knew they were correct in feeling that way. I feel like I handled it okay by showing them other resources and explaining the teacher's

higher-level background so they didn't bash him all the time, but obviously I couldn't teach them all the material they were supposed to learn and facilitate too. I definitely had to reemphasize what PAL was over the course of the semester because they expected a lot more teaching out of me.

-LAUREN

"When students ask the questions, "How will I be graded?" "When is this due?" "What should I expect?" I always defer to their TA. One, those things are not my responsibility. Two, it's really helpful to get students to go and talk to the instruction staff. Not only does the instruction staff like that, but it also sets good study habits earlier. Everybody wins when you say, "Go talk to the TA" in that situation.

It's rare that a student will ask me a content-related question that I can't answer off the top of my head. Sometimes someone will ask me, "Who won what election? By how much?" and that's not the type of stuff I'm carrying around in my mind, ready to go. So I'll say, "I don't know. Where can you find that?" If they say, "Well I can look it up in the textbook," I'll say, "Great. Can you share with the class in 3 minutes what it's about?" If they can't do that, I'll introduce them to the index and show them how to look for resources in a textbook. That's a useful moment. When somebody's curious about something, they shouldn't let a book stop them.

*"When somebody's
curious about
something, they
shouldn't let a book
stop them."*

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Sometimes students will ask something that's background material, that's in-depth or that's beyond the scope of the course. That's when PAL gets interesting. You can choose to deflect and say, "No, I'm not going to teach you about this," or you can – as I prefer to do – gauge reactions in the class, see how many people actually want to find out about the subject, and then show them if you'd like.

I think showing students things beyond what's in the class demonstrates that the facilitator is knowledgeable about the subject. It also shows the students there's more knowledge out there; you're not just going to stop here.

-JEFF

"It was always really awkward when students would talk about their TAs. It would start with one student saying something offhand, and then a bunch of other students would agree with them, and then it would turn into a class discussion. What they complained about mostly was that their TAs couldn't understand their questions or they couldn't understand their TA. They had a big language barrier.

I would encourage them to keep trying – ask your question a different way or maybe write it down to help the TA understand. I would also explain that's why we have the PAL session too. I'd say, "If your TA presents you with something you don't understand, you can bring it here." I'd also refer them to the book.

The students would bring that up almost every PAL session, and I felt like they expected me to be their TA because they didn't like their TA so much. A lot of times they would ask

me specific questions about the homework, and I felt really bad saying "I can't help with that." I would say, "We can do extra problems like that, but I can't tell you how to do your homework. That's not my job." I really did feel that pull though. It puts a lot of pressure on you.

-DOROTHY

"One of my students always spoke out in class. She couldn't keep up with the groups. She got better as the semester went on, but at first, she was dragging them down. For example, her group would be working on the first problem when everyone else was finishing the worksheet, because they had to sit there and explain each step to her. That was one issue.

Another issue occurred when we would go over the problems on the board. She would constantly raise her hand or just speak out and say, "Wait, wait, I don't get it." It got to a point where she was more of a barrier to the other people's learning because we weren't getting through the material when she was questioning every single step.

In terms of personality, she got along fine with all the other students; that wasn't the issue. It was just the learning barrier that had a negative impact. I referred her to extra help – to get tutored – which she did.

It was a constant struggle, and I had to bring her aside a couple of times. I said, "I understand that you're having difficulty with this, but you're going to need to utilize your other resources besides just this class. We need to get through these worksheets, and it's important to the other students."

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There were 25 other students in there that were on a higher level and could work a little faster. I told her that I wasn't saying her learning wasn't as important as theirs, but that we needed to work at a quicker pace to meet the majority of the students' needs. And she understood that. Her questions lessened throughout the semester, but that was also because she started to go to a tutor and was a little more on track.

-KELLEY

"My session was on a Thursday and the following Monday was a midterm for my students. The class was freaking out because there were some word problems that the lecture hadn't covered. They went crazy on me. They were like, "We don't know how to do this. No one showed us how to do this! This is totally crazy and I can't believe we're getting tested over this!" They were getting mad at me, but I'm not the person to get mad at, right? It was terrible.

I spent basically the first 25 minutes of the session going over a word problem. I know we're not supposed to re-teach or do that in PAL, but I didn't know any other way because that was all I had prepared. I spent that time going over how to tackle a word problem.

Obviously, then, that word problem was different than the next word problem I had prepared; there are a few different types that the students are supposed to learn. So we went to the next problem and they were like, "We don't know how to do this." They started freaking out again! There were, like, five mini freak-outs in the same session.

It was just awful. I felt like a terrible facilitator because I couldn't help them in anyway. I can't teach them all that material in 50 minutes. I walked out and thought, "Just breathe, go to class, try to forget about this session." And that's what I did.

The professor actually went over those problems the next day, so the students' freak-out was for no reason at all. It was just in that session when they didn't know what was going on that they went into panic mode.

There is definitely a fine line between teaching and facilitating, and I still have to tip-toe around that. The students know that I'm not there to teach them the material, and I haven't had any other problem besides that one bad session. I didn't want to tell them, "I can't teach you this," because that would've made it worse. I think it was almost better, in this case, that I did step into that role and show them how to do the problems.

-NIKETA

"I felt really good when I worked with this one girl who would stay after PAL every single time. She would always want one-on-one help and was so into everything that was going on in class. Even if she didn't understand, she would be the one giving full-attention.

One day, it was snowing really hard and nobody came to the session except for her. You would think she'd be like, "Yes! I don't have class!" but she asked, "Can I stay with you and work for an hour?" I was like, "Yeah, sure!" That was my most rewarding experience because she had such a strong desire to learn. She wanted to learn from me. It showed me that I must be

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doing my job if she wants to come that badly. If I wasn't doing my job well, she probably wouldn't have had that desire to come.

When I'd be in those 50-minute sessions with groups of students, the class would be conducted totally as PAL, but outside of the classroom or when a student would come early, I was comfortable doing one-on-one tutoring. I think that's what every student ideally wanted – they would rather me tell them everything and give them a lecture than do PAL, but our job is not to teach.

-MANDY

"One student I had really needed help. Other class members disliked being paired with her, and she knew it right away, you could tell. People would work as fast as they could to get ahead of her, and she wouldn't know what to do. They would give her short answers and turn away, because she needed so much one-on-one instruction. She needed you to write it out for her, so she could stare at it and see what to do.

You could tell she was embarrassed in the class, and there was a boy sitting across from her that was kind of in the same boat. That was good – I kept pairing them with each other. I would say, "Ask each other what you think you should do next." Or I would say, "Hey, this is what she has. Do you agree?" I directed it to both of them, so it was a little more comfortable and less embarrassing that they didn't know what to do.

The thing is it took me the whole 50 minutes to figure that out. It was awful at first; I didn't handle it well. Looking

back on it, I probably would have done it differently. I tried to just give her a hint like, "Take the derivative of this, set it equal to zero and then solve." She couldn't do the solving part though. I realized that she needed someone to stay there. So then, I sat down because none of the other students wanted to work with her. It was my mistake – I should not have sat down myself. I went into a 10-minute explanation while all the other students had questions, and I couldn't walk around.

That's why I decided to tell her about the website, and I wish I would've come up with that sooner. At the end of the very first session she came to, after I had walked her through the problems, I said, "Here's a bookmark, and here's the website. The SMART Learning Commons has private tutors so you can go there with a specific problem, and they can show you how to do it. Here, I don't have time to dedicate myself to helping only you. I need to be wandering around with everyone else. I think this would be the best option for you to set up an appointment with them." I tried to sell it the best I could by saying she could pick the time and it was free. I hope she did that.

-ALICIA

"The professor that my students had was the same one I had. He's brilliant, but he's one of those professors that makes his own examples, which are completely unrelated to what's in the book. He'd write these insane examples on the board that were really hard to follow.

The students would come in and be so angry because I would give them an example from the book, but they didn't understand the book either. Most of them had given up all hope.

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I felt like that whole semester was one disaster after another. They were angry and it was a struggle to get them to try or to look something up in their book. It was like it was too far gone for me to do anything!

I have definitely crossed the line between being a facilitator and being a teacher, but it's like, what can you do? If you put a problem on the board and nobody knows how to do it

"I couldn't let them leave having no clue because then I felt like I'd failed."

(usually at least *one* person knows), you have to put another example up or try something different. I couldn't let them leave having no clue, because then I felt like I'd failed.

The climax was when one girl got really mad; she stood up, said "I don't want to do this anymore," and turned in her papers. I said, "I can't give you attendance points if you're not going to participate." She got even madder, said "Fine," and then stormed out of the room. It was such an uncomfortable situation.

-ALLISON

"On the first day of class, I write my name, email address and phone number on the board. Giving students my phone number can be a little overwhelming if a lot of them start contacting me. I still do it though, because I'm pretty firm about saying 'no' when I'm working on my own stuff. I'm not going to stop my homework or devote a ton of time to a last-minute question before an exam. The students are always very grateful and

understanding if I can't answer a question immediately. Overall, I think giving out my number does more good than harm.

Also, giving them my phone number makes our relationship more of a peer relationship as well. Most students wouldn't text their TA or their professor, so I think that brings me down to their level a little bit. Sending a text is less intimidating than, maybe, writing out a formal email or setting up office hours.

I try to be honest if I don't know an answer for sure, and I try to lead them through the process I take to find the answer. I obviously don't want to give them incorrect information so I'll say, "Okay, I'm going to look up this related term in the index, and then go to those pages to make sure." I'm not an expert. I'm a psychology major, but that doesn't mean I know everything. When I'm not sure of answer, I say, "Oh see, that's why you have to study these things because they're easy to forget. Even I forget them."

So far I haven't had any really bad situations where I don't know an answer, but we'll see if that happens. Hopefully not – knock on wood.

-JEANNA

What do you think?

- Why do we feel the need to come to the rescue, even if it's not our job?
- When do you think it's appropriate to step outside the facilitator role and teach? How might this affect your session?

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- How can you structure your session so students do the real work while you maintain your role as a helpful peer?
- What available resources can you guide students to?
- What are some ways to manage different skill levels within your sessions?

Chapter 2: Wearing Many Hats

■ If you think tip-toeing the line between a tutor and a facilitator is a balancing act, hold onto your hats...many of them! The facilitator's role is unique in that you are a role model, but a student as well. We've been given the opportunity to both share our knowledge of a academic subject with our students, but also to form relationships, sharing experiences of other things as well.

■ Students and faculty may have a hard time defining your role, and as a result, facilitators wear many different hats. Advisor, friend, confidant, reference – you name it.

■ As you are presented with these roles, proceed with caution and mindfulness. Some roles can be beneficial to the students and rewarding to you as well, such as Kelley's experience with her coffee buddies. Other times, facilitators have been put in uncomfortable positions like Erin, a.k.a. "the shoulder to cry on", discovered. With the goals of PAL and your own instincts as guidance, you can confidently choose the hats you don.

-Lana

“ During my summer session, I had about 25 students per session twice a week; it was very high attendance. This particular girl was a transfer student, I think it was her first semester here, and she was hoping to study abroad the next spring semester. She wanted to save money by living with her

family for summer and fall semester and then go abroad in the spring.

After about three or four weeks and after the first exam, she asked if I could stay after class. I had a commitment 20 minutes after my session, but I could tell she was upset – she hadn't really been participating in the session that day. So I stayed after, and she started talking and then crying almost immediately. It wasn't hysterically, but she explained how she didn't do well on the first test. She'd been attending all of the PAL sessions, but with another class that summer, she didn't feel like she had time to do all the studying that it required.

At that point, it was nearly too late for her to drop the class or if she did, she'd be behind for the fall semester. If she didn't pass the class, then she'd have to take it again and she wouldn't be able to afford the study abroad trip. All these things – her life story almost – poured out to me, and I was in a rush. She was in this quandary of, "Do I drop the class now, or do I keep trying and risk the chance of failing it and having to take it over again?"

She also wanted me to tutor her and said that her parents were willing to pay for a tutor. I'd seen her at all the sessions so far, and I told her that I thought if she was conscious of her situation now and knew what kind of work she had to put in, she should keep going with the class. Even if she didn't get an A – if the goal was to just pass the class – I thought she could do that since we still had two-thirds of it left.

As far as the tutoring request, I said I wasn't sure it would be appropriate but that I would get back to her. I talked to Mary about that and she said that it was up to me and that if I wasn't comfortable with it, I shouldn't do it. It was kind of one

of those issues that I wanted to help her so much, but I didn't want to cross any boundaries. I was busy with my own classes and work at the time too. So that was a situation where I referred her to the SMART Learning Commons for some one-on-one tutoring. I encouraged her to get some extra help, not necessarily from me.

-ERIN

"I remember one night I was sitting on the steps outside of my house with my roommates. Three girls came strolling by, obviously drunk, one yelling my name saying I was her teacher. Having her refer to me as her teacher was weird; students who are drunk should never run into their teachers because it takes away from the professional level.

Another time, I was at a bar, and one of my students was there using a fake I.D. How do you handle that situation? He came up to me and addressed that I'm his teacher and told all of his friends. Whether it's me sitting on the step or me being at the bar, both situations are uncomfortable. If nobody was paying me to do this, I wouldn't care at all. I'd be fine with it. But the fact that I represent the U of M, that it's my job and I'm getting paid, I shouldn't be in situations like that. I should do whatever it takes to avoid them. That's hard when you and your students are both undergrads.

If I were to see my students at the gym or out playing a sport, that would be awesome. I would feel like we're on the same peer level; it'd be what PAL strives for. But the situation was inappropriate.

-MANDY

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“When you go into the PAL session, it’s all about group work, and you’re not going to work well in a group if you have no idea who you’re working with. So when I want to make that connection on a personal level, I’ll always say in my introduction to a PAL session, “Hey guys, how’s it going? How was your weekend?” If you have that little chatter beforehand, students work a lot better because the ice is broken. I wouldn’t have that if I didn’t talk to them outside of a PAL session – either before or after, or just running into them on the street.

Usually students will be there a few minutes early. Instead of sitting there quiet, I get them started in conversation, even if it’s just a couple students. That makes it easier. That’s why I love the PAL sessions. You can have that intimacy, and it all starts with making yourself available.

I also work as a tutor so when people come for chemistry help, I always say, “I run a discussion group as a PAL session, you should come!” A lot of times, I already have my PAL worksheet with me for the next day so I can show them what we’re going to go through. Even though I’ve made the announcement in lecture at the beginning of the semester, not everyone is paying attention. The people I tell that to are usually like, “Oh that’s great! I wish I would’ve known about this earlier.”

One girl has come to me as a tutor for about a year, and now she comes to PAL twice a week and my tutor hours. She and a couple other girls come to do homework, and we spend half the time talking about other things. I’ll be going to med school and a lot of the people in chemistry are thinking about going into medicine too, so I can give them advice about future

career things which is nice. It's a lot calmer in the session if you have that bond with students.

-MELISSA

"I was at the Mall of America with my mom. She said she was going to a home accessory store, so I went into American Eagle. I saw these two girls who looked so familiar to me and I just figured I knew them from the journalism school. I glanced over – they hadn't seen me yet – and walked further into the store. They saw me and were like, "Kelley, Kelley! Hiiii! How are you?" I said "Hi," but I still hadn't made the connection. Then they asked, "Hey, what are we doing in class tomorrow?" I was thinking to myself, "What are they talking about?" Then finally I realized that they were students from my PAL session.

"They really looked up to me as a role model."

We started talking a little bit, and they said, "What are you doing? We were just going to get some coffee, do you want to come?" I knew my mom was going to take forever, so I said sure!

We didn't talk a thing about math, which was good – just leave it in the classroom. They were freshman, so they were asking me about my major and things that I had done in college so far. It was cute because they were so excited about it. They thought it was really cool.

The rest of the semester, they always talked to me before or after class, or they would ask me about my weekend. It was

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nice because you don't get the opportunity to know all the people in your class on a personal level. There are always a few students, but with them, it was even a step further. I felt they really looked up to me as a role model, especially since one of the girls was thinking about pursuing journalism, my major, and so she was really into asking me about classes to take and things like that.

-KELLEY

"Living in the dorms as a junior, I see a lot of my students outside of class: in my dorm, in the dining hall, in the halls, and at the volleyball and basketball courts outside. Last semester, a group of my students would come eat with me at the dorm after our PAL session and talk – it wasn't even about math, it was just everyday stuff.

I also had office hours at the student union for an organization I'm a part of, and the same students would constantly come see me there, whether it was for math help or just to say "Hi". They knew my office hours by heart, and it seemed like I was never there alone.

I definitely think these encounters helped the PAL experience. Those students were talkative to begin with in class, and then when I started seeing them outside PAL, it became fun. I didn't always like going to facilitate their session because it was also my class of troublesome students, but all in all, it balanced out for me. We developed more than facilitator-student relationships; it was more like friendships. I think if I was in their situation, I would want to attend the session more too if I knew that it wasn't going to be strictly math, that I was going to

be able to talk casually about things and learn new things at the same time.

-LAUREN

“Since most of my students were my age, it made it really hard to always be professional because we had so many of the same interests and we did the same activities. It was hard to balance between making friends with the students and maintaining a teacher-student level. Whenever they’d get talking about what they did over the weekend, they’d go into details and wouldn’t censor what they were saying like they would have if a “teacher” was around. I wasn’t really seen as a teacher because I was so similar in age to them.

So it was very hard to get the students back on subject because they’d talk about drinking or going out, and I could relate because I was doing the same thing! It’s not something you should have in the classroom though. It was hard to get back on topic because I would put in my two cents. That was a big mistake on my part and a difficult part of being a facilitator. The hardest thing with this job is making sure you separate friend and student.

I do feel that since I was their peer, they were more comfortable talking to me and asking questions when they were confused. They knew I was still an undergrad and it allowed them to be more comfortable, but in reality, there should be different ways to achieve that comfort other than talking about sticky situations that could’ve gotten me in trouble.

Looking back, I should not have allowed talking like that in the classroom. I would have had zero talk about the

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students' outside life if it was related to drinking or partying or any topic that, in a normal classroom, wouldn't be talked about.

-MANDY

"My session was on the St. Paul campus, and all of the students lived on that campus except for one. After the sessions, we would see each other on the bus. Why not have a conversation instead of just sitting there?

She was really friendly, so we talked about almost anything: high school, college, what our plans were for after college. Through those conversations she was able to find some advice from a person a few years older than her. She was considering different careers, and one of them is what I am pursuing, medicine. She was also considering a study abroad program and asking which semester is a good one to go. She was able to ask me questions about all sorts of things.

When I think back to myself as a freshman, I realize that those opportunities aren't presented often. To be able to talk to someone who is not just one but two or three years older, and get some sincere advice ... I think it's helpful to a student's decision making

And in the session, she was more personable with me than other students just because of the opportunity we had to get to know each other.

-ALEX

"I had one situation that I was totally unprepared for. One girl, who commuted, was having problems at home, and she

"[She] was having problems at home and she confided in me about some bad things."

confided in me about some bad things. I couldn't really make assumptions, but it did not sound good. I didn't know if it was abuse or a divorce, but she was alluding to it when she explained that she was depressed and that school wasn't going well. I referred her to a counseling place on campus, and she

ended up going, which was good. I think she must have dropped the class or maybe school, I didn't find out what happened to her, but I don't think I'm supposed to know.

She was already having a bad time, and at that point in the day, I was the one who was present. She had stayed late and I was helping her, and it just all came out. I suppose it could've been anybody.

-ALLISON

"The first two semesters I worked with PAL, I had the same professor. He really liked PAL but was really controlling. He would email me every week and say, "Do these problems. This is what to go over. I want these problems handed in." I felt like a robot taking his orders. The role could've been filled by anyone, when really, I know a lot about math! There are things that I can bring forward. I have skills that I felt like I wasn't using because I was just doing what he told me to do.

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When I would do his problems, students would say, “This one’s weird because of _____” or “This one is hard.” All I could say was that he told me to do it. It wasn’t like I could say, “Well, I wanted you to learn this concept from this problem.” There wasn’t anything I felt strongly about.

“I felt like a robot taking his orders.”

I stopped doing what he was telling me to do and started picking my own problems, and I felt a lot more empowered. I could say, “This is a good example because _____.” I had a reason, and I had a plan. The last semester I did PAL I had a different professor, so I picked all of my own problems, and I felt it went way better. I felt I genuinely had a purpose and something to give.

I’m not sure if I should have had a conversation with the first professor about that. It might have helped, but then again, I don’t know how he would have responded. I think, in general, it would be a good idea to just talk to your professor. I passively-aggressively dealt with it, but it turned out fine.

-MICHELLE

“At the end of one semester, the professor that taught the course I facilitated had all of the teaching assistants over to her house for dinner and an end-of-the-semester debriefing. I went there with the TAs because the professor had invited me along as well. We had dinner and talked for about two hours about the course and the instruction. I think that kind of thing really stands out. When you form a relationship like that with a professor, it really incorporates the PAL program into the teaching of the course. If

they let you participate with the teaching team, it's really rewarding for both you and the students.

-JEFF

"Last semester, I saw one of my students at the bar, and the friends I was with were drinking a lot. I noticed that the student was sitting in the booth behind me, so I kind of kept it slow rather than keeping up with my friends. I really wasn't paying attention to her at all, but it was just the fact that she was there that made me not want to act like an idiot. It wasn't terrible, just annoying. I couldn't have as much fun as I wanted to because I didn't want to look like an idiot in front of this girl. I have to maintain some form of respect with my students.

I was nervous that she would see me and want to talk to me. If she's slurring her words or something, that puts me in an odd spot. I knew she was 21, so it wasn't a big deal, but it was just an uncomfortable situation.

-SHANNON

What do you think?

- What protocol should be followed when you encounter students in social settings?
- What situations outside the sessions could compromise your role as a leader? What situations could benefit that role?
- Do you anticipate being pressured because of your position? How so?

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- What considerations will you keep in mind when you're asked to wear a different hat by students, instructors or coworkers?

Chapter 3: Size Matters

One factor that sets PAL apart from a tutoring or consulting session is the element of size. Tutors work one-on-one while PAL facilitators can encounter anywhere from 1 to 70 students in a single session, as you'll read in this chapter's stories.

As you can imagine, the dynamics of classes with such range will be noticeably different. Large classes might thrive on team games, while small classes might enjoy working at the chalkboard. Similarly, large classes are assumed to be loud and participatory, while smaller classes are quiet. But just when you think you've developed a general rule of thumb, you'll have a class with opposite preferences.

Try not to go into your PAL session with an assumption of what a 'good,' 'bad' or even 'normal' session looks like. With the theory underlying cooperative learning in mind, students will ideally work in groups (at least two people), but as Erin concludes in the first story of this chapter, "It's not the number of students you have but the quality of work that's done."

Our facilitators reflect that when it comes to size, prepare yourself to be flexible. No two PAL sessions are created equal.

-Lana

“ The fall of 2009 was my third semester facilitating PAL. I had two sessions, and this happened at the first one. I usually had only about five students attending. It was an organic chemistry session, but it was voluntary; students didn’t have to sign up or anything.

It was right before Thanksgiving break and, of course, people leave early to go home, so only two students showed up that day. I was kind of concerned because in my other PAL session, I usually only had one or two students and it didn’t really feel like PAL. We wouldn’t really do the kind of group work that PAL promotes. In that case, the students usually weren’t as well prepared. So I was concerned, but I knew this was my better session since they were pretty good about interacting with each other.

I asked if there was anything in particular that the two students wanted to work on, but they sounded like they wanted to go with the usual set up of things, so I had them work together on the board. I found that it forces them to work together more rather than giving them even just one worksheet to share. Someone always ends up holding the worksheet, while the other person doesn’t do much of anything.

So I wrote a problem on the board for them to do – I think we were doing mechanisms at that point – and asked them to work on it together. Immediately they started working together – talking to each other and trying to figure it out. It only took them a couple minutes to finish, and then we talked about it like we usually did and discussed how they got the answer. Then, we just kept going.

It ended up being one of my best sessions, and we got through the most I’ve ever gotten through in one session. That

isn't necessarily the goal, but it was good – they did one problem after another, and I could tell they were getting exhausted by the end. They even said that when we were done. “Ugh, I’m so tired, but that was so fun!” They understood the material, and I could tell even the week after that these two students were ahead of the game and energized by coming that day.

“It’s not the number of students you have but the quality of work that’s done.”

I learned that even in voluntary sessions, it’s not the number of students you have but the quality of work that’s done. In the past, small numbers have kind of hindered my progress, but, in this case, it was the opposite experience for me. This was really one of the best sessions I’ve had because the students came ready to learn, I was prepared with enough for them to work on and they got through a lot. They said that too, which is good for me to hear as feedback. They had worked really hard, and they’d found it very beneficial.

-ERIN

“I generally would come to my session prepared with a set of questions I had generated from the book, but there were a couple of times when just one student came. She came religiously every week and I could bank on her being there. There was one other student who normally came, but neither of them had a strong grasp of the chemistry. I didn’t feel like I should have to explain it to them, though.

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So I would scratch the questions I had prepared, and I would choose a topic that was pertinent to their class work. I'd say, "Okay, go through your book and find me information about this topic. Then, you're going to teach me what you can find out about x, y, or z." That helped out a lot, and it evaded the tutor/student situation.

I would also have the two of them write questions. I would say, "Looking through your homework or your past test, write a question. It can be a question about what you did, a question about what's going on in class, or one about the material you're covering. You can write a test question or write an actual question about what you don't understand." They'd write the question, and I'd say, "Okay, now find me the answer!" I told them I would help guide them through the process, but I wouldn't tell them the answer. No one can learn like that.

-ABBY

"I've had a couple of sessions where only one student has come to PAL. When it was just me and the student, it was more like tutoring. I made sure I sat down in a chair with him so it was more comfortable, and it didn't seem like I was teaching. I didn't do anything on the whiteboard; we did it all on his paper. We both had pencils. It was more relaxed that way and kind of tutor-ish, but not teaching. I wasn't writing on the board and making him uncomfortable, like he had to shout answers out in this giant room. I did have to give quite a bit of instruction on the problems though.

When it's a one-on-one, I would say, try to make the student relaxed by sitting down with them and being like a co-person working on the problems. Make sure you are asking them questions about what they are thinking. If they do have questions, you can answer it or better, tell them where it is in the book and have them look up an example to figure it out. That's what I normally did. I try to keep the conversation light as we transition from one problem to the next as well. I would say, "Oh, what are you doing for spring break?" so they don't feel so on the spot and alone.

-ALICIA

"Last semester, another facilitator, Lauren, and I both facilitated Chemistry 1015, and we always held a test review together in a library room that holds about 30 people. The room has big tables so it works really well for a PAL session.

When the first test came around this particular semester, we decided to do it again. We made up 25 copies of our worksheet. At this time, I hadn't had really high attendance in my PAL sessions, so I didn't think too many people would come to the review. I held it on a Saturday and, as the students started flowing in 15 minutes beforehand, I ran out of worksheets before the session even started. I was also trying to pull in extra chairs because there wasn't enough seating. The 25 I expected turned into 48 students in the tiny room and, of course, it gets loud.

I had to wing a lot of it. There wasn't anyone in the library to run off extra copies or anything. Lauren, who was supposed to help me with it, was sick that day, so I was by myself. If there would've been two of us, it would've been a lot

easier to handle. There could've been a floater and then a person in front, which was what we had previously done. But she was sick, and I found out that morning, so that added to 'fun-ness.'

It actually worked out okay. You can fit five to six people around a table comfortably, so I could have a couple worksheets per table. The students had to share, which is not the most ideal situation, but because they were at the large tables, they could work together well. In fact, they were almost forced to go through the worksheet together because there weren't enough to go around. If they had a question, they could ask someone at the table first – given the probability that with four or five other people there, someone should have an answer.

It was kind of a hit or miss. Some groups breezed through the worksheet while other had questions. I floated around and answered individual table questions pretty well, but we didn't get to do as many in the front at the board together.

Surprisingly enough, after that, the attendance in my PAL sessions increased a lot. The students weren't turned off by it. I was really afraid that people were going to be like, "Oh, this is totally unorganized and weird. I don't ever want to come to one of these again."

In the end though, it was okay having 25 more people; not ideal – they were crammed in there – but okay. I learned that I need a back-up plan though. It probably wouldn't have been a big problem at all, save the worksheets, if two of us had been there to handle it. But because it was only me, I was sort of running around frantic in the beginning. Having another facilitator on call in case something goes wrong would be a good back-up plan.

-MELISSA

“The best PAL session that I’ve ever facilitated was actually a review session that was part of Cram Slam. At the end of every semester before finals week, the SMART Learning Commons holds Cram Slam day where students can come and review essentially everything they’ve learned throughout the semester for certain courses. In this particular instance, another facilitator, who facilitated Pre-Calculus 1, and I decided to do a Cram Slam event for the entire pre-calculus course. That involved two professors who taught very differently, and six other coordinating facilitators.

The one facilitator and I both really liked playing games so we decided that was what we wanted to do at this event. Sure enough, we titled our event, “Fun with Math 1051.” In the description we had all sorts of games listed, and we ended up picking two because that’s about all we felt comfortable facilitating.

The Cram Slam event was held on a Saturday, which we were a little apprehensive about because we had a lot of commuter students, and we weren’t sure if they would show up. We prepared the two games, pumped it up in our classes that week and had the other facilitators do the same, and the responses that we were getting from the students were positive. “Oh yeah, we’re coming! We’re coming.”

Truthfully though, we were envisioning that people would say they were coming, but that nobody would really show up. Well, the day of the event came, and it was supposed to go from 2:30-4:30p.m. We got there, and saw over 70 people in the lobby area waiting to get into this room. We were like, “Ohhh my goodness, we do NOT have enough seating and we

*“Ohhh my goodness,
we do NOT have
enough seating and we
do NOT have enough
material.”*

do NOT have enough material.”

We were perplexed at how we were going to handle it.

Thankfully, we were able to get everyone in the room. We split the class in half, so I had 35-ish students and the other facilitator had 35-ish students as

well, each working on a different game. During the work time, we had another person run and make more copies of the materials. It was hectic, but at the same time, the games provided a nice way for us to sit back and see what the students knew. It also allowed us to see the different group dynamics at play.

I was prepared to do a lot more teaching or reminding of what the concepts were, but I didn't have to do any of that. The groups worked fantastically together, and we hardly had to interrupt to help the students along the process. It just went so smoothly, and we had an amazing turnout! That's the way it's supposed to be, and that's why it was the best PAL experience for me so far.

-JERED

“I've had two or three awful PAL sessions in my life. The first one was my very first day ever of PAL because I prepared this worksheet and only one student showed up. I didn't really know what to do with him! I gave the worksheet to the student, but he didn't know how to do the problems. It was the first week of

school, he didn't know what he was doing, and all I got was a blank stare.

I tried to guide him, but he still didn't know, so I ended up showing him how to do the first problem. We moved to the next question and the same thing happened...over and over again. Eventually, the student started to do the work on his own, and he made it through some of the sheet – but just a little bit. I said, “Hey, you know, it's way before the class is over, but I think it's time we call it a day.”

I never saw him again. The next week I had six people come, and then eight, and bigger and bigger, but that one student was really turned off by being there alone and a one-on-one session.

It doesn't mean that's always going to happen though. I've had another student who came alone one day and LOVED it – he loved being one-on-one. He could solve the problem, and I could sit there and say, “Oh, you have a mistake here,” or “Yeah, that's the right step. Good job!” It was probably more uncomfortable for me because I would just sit there, stare and wait while his mind processed, or ask him to explain what he was doing as he went. For him though, he was very focused and comfortable the whole time. He had been there numerous times before in a group so he didn't mind the one-on-one.

I think it depends on the person, because the one who loved it was prepared and knew the material. He was running through problems, bam, bam, bam. The first-day student had no idea. It was stressful, but I'm sure he found a way to get through the class on his own.

-ALICIA

“In one particular session, I had fewer students than usual so I was worried. I thought it might not go so well but it turned out that the smaller group helped because students who didn’t talk much before couldn’t hide behind their peers as often. It also helped that I made copies of the readings this time. We mostly just dissected readings –there were no tests, just papers. I handed out the reading so the students could all go through it and have something to refer to, which I think was a huge help. They could read out a quote, or if they didn’t have their own answer, they could find it in the text.

I was very impressed with the insights the students gave and with their enthusiasm. When I asked, “Who wants to write this on the board?” I think three hands shot up. That never happens! I don’t know if someone spiked all their coffee that day or what it was, but they were just really excited about PAL. After that session, I had my most well-attended session yet. That enthusiasm carried over, and they saw that PAL works.

The enthusiasm tapered off after a few weeks, but I think it helped me identify what the students respond to. I had them make a compare/contrast chart between two different readings; giving them a little more structure in an activity is good sometimes. They had a direction to go in, rather than simply, “Let’s discuss this.” Comparing the views of the two authors really set off some light bulbs for some of the students.

Mainly, the lower attendance seemed to help this session. Some people who usually dominated the conversation weren’t there so other people felt more comfortable speaking. They had more time to process, and they could actually raise their hand and contribute.

It made me really happy. I was kind of walking on clouds for the rest of the day. It probably wasn't a lot that I did, but I still felt really good at the end.

-AMANDA

"I wasn't having very good attendance at my PAL sessions even though I'd gone to the students' lectures and handed out fliers about PAL to make sure people knew about it. I'd been having maybe two or three students for the most part. This was from a lecture of 200-300 people, and I was only getting one percent of

"From a lecture of 200-300 people, I was only getting one percent of the students!"

the students! It was completely optional for them, but I was still getting pretty annoyed.

I thought, "Okay. We have a test coming up and it's the first midterm. It's probably a good time to get people to come to PAL and gain exposure for the program." I emailed three of the chemistry

classes, so I probably contacted close to 1,000 students. I didn't put anything in the email that said to reply or R.S.V.P., but a few people emailed me back.

When the day of the session came, I was prepared with enough worksheets for 24 students because that was the number of seats in the room. People showed up and filled the seats. People kept showing up even after the session had started, like this was a review session that you could just walk into at any time. I was just so frustrated with the constant amount of people

just showing up! They were freshmen, it was their first exam, and they were stressed.

By this point I had tried to explain PAL, and every time someone new came in, I had to re-explain the goals of PAL. I wasn't going to stand there and tell them the answers to what was going to be on the test, right? They needed to use each other as resources because me giving the answers was not going to help them remember it for the test.

I set them up in groups of four or five, and each group had two worksheets to work off of. Two or three groups just took a couple copies of the worksheet and moved out of the room as well. I actually appreciated that they saw I was struggling, took the initiative, and said, "Okay, we'll take your questions and we'll make a study group out of this situation."

I kept contact by just floating around to the groups in my room. It was hectic and busy and I was totally unprepared for it. I hadn't thought that more than 50 people would come, and I didn't think they'd have as many questions as they did. I expected them to be more prepared for the midterm since it was so close.

I learned a lot from it; I learned to have a back-up plan that works on a whiteboard if you run out of worksheets. I started coming to my PAL sessions with a few tricks prepared to work things out in a less-structured fashion. "Okay, we have ten people here today. Let's go ahead and do the worksheet," versus "Okay, there's 50 people here today. Let's focus on working on the board and doing things on scratch paper. I'll write questions on the board and you'll work on it in your groups." The problem with the worksheet that day was that each of the 12 groups was on a different question. As a facilitator, that becomes really

difficult to manage. So being flexible with my agenda was what I learned from that day.

-ABBY

What do you think?

- What impact does size have on the quality of the session? On the group dynamics?
- What techniques will you use for smaller sessions? How do those change for larger sessions?
- What problems might arise in a smaller session that could compromise your role or the students' learning? In a larger session? How will you adapt to these?

Chapter 4: Challenging Behaviors

In many education and leadership trainings, new employees are alerted to some common personality types they might encounter in their work. One example is the complainer, who never seems to be satisfied with his or her task or the environment. Then there is the clinger, who doesn't seem to want to think on his or her own. Especially fun is the unaccountable personality, a.k.a. "I didn't know we needed our books today."

These types of students, we've come to expect – and we learned how to work with them too. It's when student behavior falls outside of those personality types that we start scratching our noggins. These students fall in no other category than challenging.

-Lana

“Last semester, I had Pete*, who was a non-traditional student, probably mid-40s or so, and hadn't done math for years. I think it was probably his first semester of school at the U of M as well. It was an 8 a.m. class, so he often came in late saying he had to bring his daughter to school or something else. That wasn't really the disturbance, because I told him that if he comes more than 10 minutes late, I wouldn't count him as there. The disturbance was that he asked so many questions that it bothered the rest of the class because they were moving along with the material, and he was not.

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Whichever group he was in would get stuck on one problem because he would have questions about every single step of it– which isn't necessarily a bad thing, but it got to be too much. The students in his group would get frustrated because he wouldn't understand what they were trying to say. I would try to step in and that wouldn't work, so I'd say, "Let's wait until we bring the problem to the board." Even then, he'd have more questions. It was just a never-ending cycle.

Sometimes I'd say, "Okay, well let's wait until they're done with the problem to see if you have these questions still." I would redirect the questions to the class or the person at the board to see if they could answer his questions for him. If his questions were too much, which they were a couple of times, I'd say, "Let's talk about this after class. We'll talk about some different resources you can use."

It was hard for me to maintain composure in that situation because people were getting so frustrated with his constant questions. It was most challenging to be really patient with him and explain that there are resources he can use other than this classroom and that maybe he should explore them.

-SHANNON

"One of the students that was actually part of my best session would come every week, and he was really fun. He was always willing to work with other people too. I think he did well on the first exam – he seemed pleased – but for some reason, he started saying the class was too hard and there was no way he was going to do well; he would just be happy if he got a 40% on the exam. He said it all with a smile on his face, but it bothered me

because it wasn't just directed at me; it was to the whole group. People would turn and say, "Oh I know, it's so hard." They may not have agreed with everything he said, but just the fact that he was bringing these comments into the session was troublesome.

So I said, "Why are you saying that? You're just setting yourself up to fail if that's all you're shooting for. You've been coming to PAL every week, and you're doing a great job working. I know you can do better. I know you can ALL do better." I tried to make it a group message.

I don't know any of his scores after that. The class got harder, so I understood that part of his complaints; if you ever fall behind, it's hard to catch up. But he kept having this bad attitude. He was never disparaging of PAL; he kept attending and participating. So I don't know if that was his defense mechanism or not – if saying, "anything above 40%" was his way of setting himself up to be happy no matter what happened.

I felt it was really important to address his attitude and make sure it didn't spread to other students' attitudes in the class. I think I said the same things every time – just reminding students that they're putting in all this work, and that if they go into the class with very low expectations, they are probably not going to do as well. Keep them up. I tried to emphasize that even if you don't get 100%, you should still have high goals – you should have something you're shooting for. If you're attending PAL, you must want to do well; you're already putting in extra time by being here.

I think by the end, he stopped saying the comments. It was weird though because he would also say how great PAL was and how he always felt good after the session. I don't know if it was just his insecurities, but I tried to make sure he knew

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that I believed in him, and that I knew he could do better. He'd already proven himself to be a much better student than that.

-ERIN

"My biggest problem with Steven* was that every discussion and question I brought up, he managed to relate to something completely off topic. He didn't have a lot of awareness of social boundaries either; he would say very inappropriate things like, "I stole three bikes this weekend!" These are things that you should not tell people. I mean, he would snort Pixy Stix while in the session, and I couldn't quite believe he was a real person.

I thought his energy was really good though. I have some cousins who, as children, were wild, and I thought if it's possible to divert that energy into something constructive, they can become great students or great children. That was my

*"He would snort Pixy Stix
while in the session ... I
couldn't quite believe he was
a real person."*

philosophy with Steven:
let's direct this energy
into something useful for
PAL. I wish I had started
doing that right away in
the semester; I wish I
would have recognized
sooner that he was going

to become a problem because the more I let him talk at the beginning of every session, the more out of hand he got.

Finally I figured out how to redirect things or straight-up cut him off, and say, "Hey, you gotta let someone else talk. You gotta get back on topic." I even had a discussion with the entire class and said, "If you don't want to be here for five

minutes after class, you have to stay on topic and stay focused on your work.” It was mostly directed at Steven, but it was a way to confront him without having a one-on-one confrontation.

In one case, I had the students talk about their personal experiences with arguing with their parents. It was a public speaking class, and we were breaking down different ways to make persuasive arguments. I figured this topic was something easy that everyone can answer. How do you persuade your parents to extend your curfew? Questions like that. In that case, whenever he would go off topic, I could say, “Oh, that’s a good example of _____,” and then bring it back to what we were trying to discuss. Or I would say, “Can anyone identify that method in Steven’s story?”

When it comes to classroom management, I try to imagine myself as one of the students, and I think, “How annoyed would *I* be if this was going on?” I try to read the students’ expressions. They liked his stories – he did have some really entertaining ones amid the really inappropriate ones. So, I would let the students talk before the session started. But when Steven went off topic, I would have to ask the students to work with me to redirect him. I would ask, “Does anyone else have a similar situation?” or “What do you guys think of that?”

I thought the students were really generous with him considering how absurd he was sometimes. They were all still friends with him at the end of the session, and I tried not to take advantage of that. It would have been easy for me to let him go on, especially if the students weren’t showing a lot of body language to indicate that they were annoyed, but I also had to measure the level of appropriateness in the classroom. If you don’t call someone out, eventually the students are going to do it

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for you, and I think that's how you lose control of the session – when you're not asserting your authority at the right time or right place.

I called him out, but very gently. I really did appreciate his enthusiasm; he did make good points. It was just that his good points came with another 20 minutes of dialogue or narrative for him. I've now learned to stop this kind of behavior earlier.

-AMANDA

"The majority of the students in my sessions have been from different cultures and English is their second language. The PAL session was originally created for them, and they've actually made jokes when someone else comes to the class. For example, they'll say, "Why'd she come? She knows English!" I have to remind them that the session is available for everybody. They're joking so I address it jokingly as well, because they aren't mean to anyone by any means. They know that the session was started for them, so they react that way.

When the session is just students with English as second language, the dynamic is different. We can move at a slower pace all together. When someone else comes who understands English better, it kicks up the pace because you're trying to cater to both groups.

Also, the Chinese students have told me that, in their culture, learning comes from repetition. Architecture is more about concepts and abstract ideas – it's not something you memorize, but something you learn how to think about. They've had a hard time with that, and I've really had to figure out ways

to get them to think crazier. I'm constantly reminding them that there's not always a right answer, and I do little mini-projects in class, replicating what they're doing in the actual class. It's always scary starting these crazy projects when you don't know what you're doing. We do it on a smaller scale so they can jump right in and practice.

-BETH

"There was a kid in the front row of the math lectures who would blow his nose so loudly that one day the professor turned around from writing on the board and said, "Stop that!" She snapped at him in lecture! I didn't know who the student was though.

Meanwhile, I had noted in our team meetings that there was a student in my session who seemed to be just a little off. He didn't seem to be really present. He was clearly very smart, but he wasn't fitting in socially. One day, he started blowing his nose in my session, and I knew it was him.

His behavior proceeded to puzzle me. I think he just got bored. He would come, take out his laptop and work on it. He wouldn't work in groups no matter what I tried to get him to interact. I would assign him to a group using cards or numbers so he would have to get up and move, but the other group members didn't know what to do with him either. They tried to talk to him, but he was unresponsive and would mostly just sleep.

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He would take up the back row table, pull out the chairs, lie down and take a nap! I'd go back there and see that he'd have a couple problems done. I didn't know what to do, because I

"He would take up the back row table, pull out the chairs, lie down and take a nap!"

assumed he was dealing with some kind of disorder – like autism or Asperger's. I knew he was getting the concepts, he just wasn't participating. I kind of left him alone, and I think eventually he stopped coming.

-ALLISON

"A challenging student that I had was an English-language learner student. For other subjects, you can provide visuals and other aids to make more sense of the material, but what you do with numbers and math, everything is spoken and written. You can't provide another visual aid. If a student speaks primarily a different language, it makes it really hard to get through to them.

He spoke some English, and he was obviously doing well enough to be in college, but I could tell he struggled. When he was asked to respond and had to use a sentence, the words were never in the right order. How can you teach them and how can they understand and learn from their peers when they struggle to speak themselves? He wasn't a bad student, but he was a challenge in the session.

When he didn't have to talk, he kept to himself. In group work, he would talk a little bit but not much. He never stayed after or came ahead of time. On his worksheet, he could fill

everything out pretty accurately – he knew his math – but it was hard for him to talk about it.

In discussion, I wanted to incorporate as much material support as I could with that student. I would find where that same type of problem was in the book and show him. When I was talking to him, I got the impression that I might not be getting through to him, even though he might already know the material. The communication block was just the biggest struggle because I never knew how much he understood of what I was saying.

-MANDY

“One of my students used to skip sessions a lot. The student was rather knowledgeable, and I recognized that he may have been more of an auditory learner; he learned from listening in lecture rather than writing things down.

There was a long period when this student skipped PAL, but he showed up again closer to the exam. I made reviews but the student wouldn’t write anything down. He’d just sit there. I asked him, “Why aren’t you writing? What are you working on?” He’d respond, “I already know this.”

At first, I didn’t believe him so I said, “Alright, why don’t I quiz you?” So I did, and he did know the material. There was even a question that he managed to stump me on. I was like, “Oh wow. You’re right.”

“So I proved you wrong, huh?”

“Yes, you did. Congratulations. Clearly, you know what’s going on, but I would still suggest studying and reviewing to use the time wisely.”

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“Oh okay, I can do that.”

Then the student asked, “By the way, how much are the attendance points worth?” I told him that it was up to the course coordinator and mentioned that I’d noticed he’d been absent for a while. I explained that he’d be losing attendance points for that. He then approached me with the idea that for every question he could stump me on, he should get attendance points back. My first reaction was, “No. No, that’s ridiculous!” He was like, “Come on, I know what I’m doing. That doesn’t mean I need to be here.”

It was incredibly frustrating hearing this from a student, and basically I had to go through the explanation of PAL again to explain that he wasn’t contributing. I said, “It doesn’t matter if you’re here if you’re not participating. You’re not getting the point of PAL. It’s not a free study period.”

This conversation went on for a couple sessions, and we finally worked it out. I’ve seen a drastic change when he comes to sessions now. He makes an effort to be on time when he used to be really late. He’s more actively participative, and he’s realized that I’m not going to give him back the points. I’ve put my foot down on this matter.

-SOO

“Gina* was definitely a bright student. I think she got As and Bs on her tests, so she was focused on learning chemistry. But she wasn’t one of the best team members. She was very focused on her own worksheets and tried to get the right answers, so she would check the answers with me. She was much faster than the others too.

My first response would be, “Check with you teammates.” Of course I knew her team was not there yet, but still. She would relentlessly go for the answer, which is something I usually don’t give out. I usually have different groups present and that’s how the rest of the class checks their answers. Her attitude was that as long as she knew she got the right answer, she didn’t have to look at the problem again.

It’s difficult to work with the demand of one student when you’re trying to look at the overall goal of PAL, which is peer-assisted learning, instead of individual tutoring. She was an individual worker, and it was hard for me to encourage her to help others.

For me, if a student isn’t negatively affecting other people’s attitude or behavior, I usually won’t have a head-on confrontation with them. And Gina wasn’t affecting the others that way. I really just encouraged her to work in her group, indirectly guiding her to do more PAL work.

-ALEX

“One troublesome student I have seems to think that I can’t see him in class. He’ll sit there and work on something else. It really never occurred to me how visible a single student is in a class until I’m sitting at the front going, “Okay, that guy is not paying attention.” You don’t think about that until you have your own classroom.

Only if I address him by name will he actually participate. It’s problematic because if one student can sit and do something else, other students will want to work on something else too. That’s just not helpful at all.

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I'll ask what he's doing sometimes, and he'll say he's doing work for the class because he has the coordinating TA discussion directly after PAL. While it's a good use of his time, it's not the appropriate use of his time. One thing I do to keep students involved is to give them the option of choosing what they'll do next week. Most of the time though, I just structure activities so it's impossible for this student to work on other things. I'll use paired activities or something where I rotate through all the students in the class. I've talked to him about it privately, and he says every time, "I won't do it next week," but every week, there he is again. The most I can do is to keep saying, "You're going to have to participate at some point."

-JEFF

"PSEO¹ students either proved to be a little bit challenging, or they were all-stars who just took over the class. Sometimes that was good; sometimes it wasn't. I had one student who flew through the worksheet and then just sat there staring at the wall. That's a little troublesome. Typically what I did was set up groups where he was with students who I'd noticed were struggling a bit more so he had to answer their questions.

He was a good student to have though because he was always willing to go to the board, and he was always right. It was also helpful when a student asked me a question; I could redirect it to the rest of the class, and he would have the answer. He wasn't a jerk about it either. He seemed willing to help, but

¹ "Postsecondary Enrollment Options (PSEO) is a program that allows students in their junior or senior year to earn college credit while in high school," (Minnesota Department of Education, 2010).

he was quieter. When I put him in a situation where he could answer a question, it was better. It was pressure off of me.

I just had to figure out what to do with the student. It's not really troublesome if you know how to handle their different abilities.

-SHANNON

"All of the freshmen in Animal Sciences are required to take a PAL session for their chemistry class. There were four facilitators leading Chemistry 1015 sessions. The students had a weekly seminar class right before PAL, so all 80 of them were in a big lecture hall. We would do a 15-minute activity with them until the classrooms were free. We'd split up into groups and work through problems. For example, we would call out birthdays and those students had to come down and do the problem on the board. Then we'd take them to small classrooms and conduct our PAL sessions in groups of 20.

Will* was one of the students in my session. He was super outspoken and was the class clown in high school. When I'd ask for help with him in our PAL team meetings throughout the semester, I'd refer to him as the "too-cool-for-school kid." He was actually pretty bright and sometimes he'd do great with getting our worksheet done; when I'd ask for a volunteer, he'd be like, "Oh yeah, I'll do it!" Then, other times, it'd be the total opposite. He'd say, "Why am I even here? I hate this. You guys better get paid for this, because this is crap." He did it to get a rise out of his friends, and that was obvious; it was really easy to tell.

In the beginning when it wasn't anything too big, I'd let it go or just say, "Okay, if you're done already, try this problem," just to challenge him more. It seemed to work.

Then one day in the lecture hall, Will was being really disrespectful. Previously, the facilitators had been walking around to the groups, and he had just been refusing to do the problems. I actually sent Lauren, another facilitator, up to go referee that group because she has four kids and has more of a motherly sternness that I don't always possess. So she went up

"Someone from the other side of the lecture hall yelled, 'Dude, that is so disrespectful!'"

and helped them get through the worksheet, while the rest of us floated around.

When we came back as one big group, I started going through one of the worksheet problems on the board, and Will literally yelled out something that the whole room could hear. It was silent because I was talking. I didn't understand what he said – I wish I would've heard it! – but then someone from the other side of the lecture hall yelled, "Dude, that is so disrespectful!" Will shut up so fast, and I didn't have a problem with him after that point.

He was doing it to impress other people but when someone else called him out on it, he totally lost his steam. Once the class stopped laughing and he realized that not everyone loved him, he acted a lot better. He was more respectful and quiet compared to the way he was. It would still make me a little bit nervous when I would think, "Well, what's he going to say next? How do I discipline him?" There's a fine line between discipline and "I'm your peer."

You know, you go through the PAL trainings and the various scenarios like, “If you have a bad student, do this or do that,” but they don’t seem to apply until you see it yourself. Because he was so participatory in the beginning, I wasn’t quick to tell him to reel it back in. I wanted that participation; I wanted him to keep leading the group. It’s a lot easier for some students to talk if someone else talks first. But I definitely learned my lesson: rein it in a lot sooner so you don’t have someone yelling out disrespectful things to the PAL facilitators in front of 80 students in a large lecture.

I mean, we’re here because we like facilitating and because we get paid, but there are lots of other places where we could get a paycheck. We want to be here and we want to help.

-MELISSA

“One day last semester, my session was playing a game, and one student came late. I asked her to join a group and participate. The groups were to try to get as many right answers as they could and get candy.

The girl said, “I don’t want to do it. I hate math, it’s the morning and I don’t care about candy.” Then she just sat there, individually, and didn’t do anything. She just opened the newspaper and read it. Her classmates kept looking at her like it was her fault, not my fault. They just stared at her, questioning, “Why did you come here to not do anything?” I didn’t know what to do. Should I say, “If you don’t want to be here, leave,”? I didn’t want to be mean.

It’s not a good thing to ignore students though, so I tried to encourage her and show her that learning from other people

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is a really good way to do this. She didn't care at all, and she only came that one week. She never tried, so how can she know whether it would help or not? If she had tried to play the game and didn't like it, I would agree, but she never tried. She didn't even do it individually.

I am the PAL facilitator, and I have the authority – a little bit – to tell her what to do in my session, but she didn't listen to me. When I talk to students, I'm not ordering them or controlling them; I don't facilitate that way. It's usually in a polite way like, "Can you do ___?" or "Would you like to ___?" Most of the students do it, and they never react to me in a bad behavior. But she didn't care. What can you do?

-ANH

"One girl in my PAL session finishes the entire worksheet in the time that the rest of her group finishes a third of it. When they ask her questions, she explains it to her group like she is talking to fifth-graders. I go over there and direct the explanation by saying, "How did you know how to do that? Why did you do this?" so she can't talk down to them, but she doesn't like that. She looks at me like, "What are you doing here? I'm trying to help them, and only one of us is needed. If *you're* going to help them, then I want to leave." You can tell a lot from facial expressions!

The group finally gives up asking her and goes back to work. She just sits there and stares at the worksheet. Then, the next thing you know, I'll be working with a group and she'll walk up to the front, put the worksheet on the table and walk out of the room. She never asks if we're done; she doesn't know

if that's all we're doing for the day. I'll go back to the group and ask, "Did she just leave?" and they'll say, "Yeah, yeah, but that's okay! We'll figure it out. If anything, we'll join that group over there." The group definitely likes it better when she's not there.

The student knows what she's doing, but that's not the purpose of PAL obviously. That's why it's hard to know where to draw the line. If she's actually making it worse for PAL and for everyone else, is it bad to let her leave? Should she be staying to help them if she's just going to talk down to them?

I haven't addressed her about it, but I have been adding more activities at the end of the class, so that when she does stay, she sees we do more. In that sense, she knows that she can't just leave.

-LAUREN

"I have a student who comes every week and doesn't do anything, so I'm not sure why he comes; he's not required to at all. He'll come, sit there and won't do anything until I say, "Okay, you guys have two minutes left." Then he'll start asking people around him what they wrote.

He's actually in another class with me just as a student. We were given a study guide, and he emailed me and said, "Everything is going good in the course that you facilitate, but could you type up the answers to this study guide and email

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them to me?" I was like, "What?? NO!" I definitely told him 'no' and explained that the whole point of him doing the study guide and the activities in PAL is to learn through experience and talking with his peers, and that me giving him the answers won't help.

He stopped coming for a couple weeks after that, but now he is back and he still lingers around not doing much. I'm still trying to figure out how to deal with him. I try, as much as I can, to help him along because English is his second language. I know that it's a barrier for him, so I ask him if there are any words he doesn't know. He's still very hesitant to work on his own. Hopefully he's gaining something by listening, but until he decides to do the work, I can only help him so much.

-BETH

"I had a girl who came to my PAL sessions regularly but definitely struggled with the material. She didn't know how to start a problem and needed some serious guidance. She would try to get started, but when she got stuck, she would automatically turn to me and say, "What do I do now?" I'd say, "Why don't you ask someone else beside you?" I'd walk away and she'd do nothing. I would walk back and ask, "Did you figure that out?"

"No. Is it right? Do I do it like this?"

"Did you ask anyone?"

"No."

Then I'd ask another student for her myself. "So, Mike, can you help her with this part?"

"Okay, sure."

She got a little better at asking other students for help, but still every problem, halfway through, she'd ask me, "Is this

right? What do I do next?" Every time. Sometimes I would give in. I'd lean over her shoulder, explain it, check it out, and tell her she was doing great, but it was really distracting me from leading the session. It was hard for the other students because I was always being pulled away to discuss with her. Then, I would have to gather my thoughts again and try to make my way around the class while she was always calling me back over. That was very hard to deal with.

I think I handled it pretty well by trying to turn her to other students. All she needed was someone to say, "This is the step," or "Yeah, you're doing it right," or "This is what you missed." It was not a walk-me-through-and-hold-my-hand-the-entire-problem situation; she only needed a one-minute explanation. I think if she could have taken the verbal initiative herself, she could've done it. When I encouraged her to ask questions, she would, so it did get better for her.

-ALICIA

What do you think?

- What expectations do you hold for your students?
- How can you hold them accountable to these?
- At what point should you intervene with challenging behavior?
- When, if ever, does a student become a lost cause?
- What behavior(s) are you most worried about encountering? How will you handle them?

Chapter 5:

Wielding Authority

A pillar of the PAL model is that facilitators be seen as peers by the students they work with. It's not like the relationship between student and professor, nor is it like the relationship between tutor and student. You present yourself as a model for the class to observe and learn from. For example, when your students' first test approaches, you could design a study guide and let the students fill in the blanks, explaining why this is a method you would use. You can show them valuable tips to make their studying more effective.

Equally important is that you create a comfortable, casual atmosphere for students to learn in. This might mean talking about things outside of PAL like the past weekend or future plans, or it might mean making jokes with students. You want them to feel at ease around you and around each other.

There are instances, however, when "I'm your peer" can have its downsides. Students sometimes get used to your friendliness and feel they can take advantage of it or get away with anything. While we want to preserve our peer status, there are some situations that call for a good ol' fashioned round of laying down the PAL law. We don't have a lot of authority, but when a behavior is taking away from learning, it's appropriate to exercise some. Hey, sometimes you just have to be a bit of a meanie...

-Lana

“ For a recent session, I made a skeleton PowerPoint slideshow. The headings on all of the slides were questions that corresponded to different study guide questions. I brought my laptop and hooked it up to the projection system in the class so students could see the question. There were no answers on the slides.

For this activity, I take a seat with the students out in the classroom area, and they take turns coming up to my computer and typing in the answers while their classmates direct them with what to type. I actually have a rule that you can't bring up your books or notes because I don't want one person to be up there doing all the work.

It went really well in my first session. I've done it before and they usually love it because they're getting the information, there's lots of time to discuss the answers if they don't understand something, and I email them the PowerPoint slides at the end so they don't have to worry about scribbling down frantic notes.

My second session...was silent. I asked for a volunteer to go up and type at the computer, and nobody said a word. I was like, "We can sit here, but that's going to be pretty boring." So finally, one person says he'll go up and type. He sits at the computer, reads the question out loud, and everyone is silent. I sat there for probably 30 seconds, which is a pretty awkward amount of time. I gave the students a clue, told them to look at a certain section of the book, and finally someone shared an answer. The two of them talked about it, put the answer up and we moved onto the next slide.

After going through three or four different questions, only four different students had participated in speaking or

typing – four out of twelve. It wouldn't be a big deal – well, it kind of still would – if I felt like the other students were at least paying attention and getting a lot out of it. But that wasn't the case; I felt like they were just spacing off.

I had some candy in my backpack that I had planned to use the next week, and I gave some to the four students. I said,

“This activity is NOT going to work if we sit here in silence for 50 minutes.”

“Nice job, looks like some other people should have participated...,” and I expected that would do the trick. Well, it worked for one person, but more than half of the class still wasn't participating.

Finally, I took out the attendance sheet that had been passed around and I said, “I'm not trying to be mean, but you have to participate. So far, five people are going to be emailed the slides tonight because they're the only ones who've participated.” I started making stars by their names. I said, “This activity is NOT going to work if we sit here in silence for 50 minutes.” The ones who were participating laughed about it and were like, “Yeah, come on guys. Help us out!”

It didn't seem like the class felt I was being too much of an authority figure, but it needed to be done. It had already been awkward for five minutes, and I didn't think I could handle another 45 minutes of awkward.

I really would've only sent the slides to those people because PAL is about collaboration. At that point though, it kind of forced the other ones to participate. I told them that they didn't have to know the answers. Even if they knew absolutely

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nothing, they could still go sit at the computer and have their classmates tell them what to type.

After I said that, I was kind of worried that they really hated the activity. But I was like, “Oh well. For this session, they’re going to have to deal with it.” But by the end, they were asking questions, sharing examples and asking, “Hey, can you put that on the slide too? I want to remember that example.” I asked them if they liked the activity, and they were all like, “Yeah, we should do it next week!”

It was really strange to me. I don’t know if they were getting used to the different type of participation or what it was. It will be interesting to see what happens the second time I use it with them.

-JEANNA

“PAL is peer-assisted learning, and you can interpret that two ways. The person leading your facilitation is your peer, and they’re helping you learn. But then there are the peers who are your classmates, also learning and helping you learn in return. As a facilitator, it’s really difficult to figure out where you fit.

Is it my place to say, “Stop what you’re doing,”? Or “Stop making phone calls,”? Or “Stop looking at cows,”? Yeah, one girl in my class bought cows – these were Animal Science students – and one day, instead of paying attention to me, she was searching online for a new heifer. I didn’t know you could buy cows on the Internet, but apparently you can! I think I said something like, “I know this is important to you, but right now we’re doing chemistry. I think you need to wait and buy your cow later.”

It's hard because you don't really want to be an authoritarian. You don't want to tell them what to do. In an ideal PAL situation, all the students would have a desire to learn that was internally motivated. In reality, that's not always the case, so you have to be prepared to become an authority figure of sorts. It's hard to make the distinction between facilitator and peer, but not disturb the comfort level students have with you. It's difficult, but a good relationship in the session can be really rewarding.

-ABBY

"I had a somewhat nontraditional student who had been out of school for a while. I knew he was older than me, and he probably knew that too. He expressed doubt one day saying that lecture was three times a week, discussion was once a week – so that's already four out of the five days – and then they have PAL. The students felt that in comparison to their other classes, sociology was taking up a lot of time. They felt they had harder classes and wanted to spend more time on those.

It wasn't hostile the way he asked, but it was more like, "What's the point? I'm tired of this. I want to work on other things. Can I do that?" He asked if they could work on other homework during the session. If he, or anyone else, had approached me separately and asked to discuss it, I know it would have been fine. This time, however, it was posed in the middle of the session and in a way that everyone could hear. I was apprehensive about how to approach it.

I basically stressed the aim of PAL. The students were there to become independent learners and to use all the

resources available to them. I told the students I wanted them to tell me what they wanted to learn in PAL, but no one had been doing that. As a result, I was forced to use my own judgment. I had to come down a little sternly and say, “You need to tell me what’s going on and how you’d like to utilize your time. You need to communicate because that’s one of the most important tools you have in college. If you don’t practice it now, you’re not going to develop it later on.”

I didn’t have a problem with the class after that or with that student. He was one of the students who participated in PAL the most, which is why I was surprised the comment came from him. I mean, if he’s feeling that way, then I can’t imagine what the people that never talk were feeling. That’s why I addressed the whole group.

-SOO

“Last spring, I had a girl who was in PSEO, so she wasn’t really in college yet. She still had kind of a high school attitude: ‘I want you to give me everything.’ Once, she just got up and left class in the middle of it. She was one of the best at understanding the material, and she would always finish early. That’s why she wanted to leave. Do the bare minimum to get a good grade. She didn’t care about helping others or participating as a peer. She would just do the problems then spit out all the answers so no one else got to work or give it a try.

She never played the games either, but talked all the time. I handled that poorly because I never really did anything about it. One student actually came up to me and asked, “Could you say something to her? Because it’s really disrupting me and

this class.” Even though only one guy said it, I think a lot of the class was thinking it. I talked to her after class once, but I don’t feel like I was forceful enough or assertive about it. I kind of tried to make it as light and friendly as possible.

I didn’t fix the problem that semester, but the next semester I stated my rules much more clearly from the beginning. I guess they’re not really rules, but what I expect. For example, if you leave class, you won’t get

“Don’t back down from an awkward situation. Sometimes you just have to face it.”

participation points for that day. Also, if I feel you aren’t participating, it’s my judgment whether you get the points. I just made that up, but I needed to be clear. I never had a problem with that again.

In the first incident, I definitely could’ve handled it better. I should’ve done something, but instead, I just laughed it off. I should have addressed it seriously. “You are disrupting this class. We are here to learn. It’s fun, but it’s not a free hour.” Don’t back down from an awkward situation. Sometimes you just have to face it.

-MICHELLE

“One girl was such a flirt with all the boys. She would sit with the same three guys, right in the middle, and would always dress up for PAL. You could tell she was going out of her way to be a flirt. She’d whisper to them, talk to them – anytime I’d turn my back to that group, I could hear her talking!

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I asked her over and over again to get to work. I didn't get really mad with her, but I had to separate them. When I would ask the students to do group work and find a partner, she'd always go right back to those guys. It came to the point when she seriously had assigned seating, without her knowing it. She sat in her one spot, and I never had the class get up anymore to do group work. I would walk around and say, "Okay, you two are sitting next to each other. You two, you two, you two..." Everything I did involving more than one person was to make her not be with these boys!

But she'd still walk in with them, talk, talk, talk, talk across the room, smile at them, and pay zero attention to what the class was doing. It was absolutely terrible. I didn't really know how to handle it other than splitting them up. After I talked to her a couple times in class, I asked her to stay after. I was very casual, not mean or mad. I just asked that she actually pay attention and not side-talk to the guys. It got a little better the next week, but then it went right back.

It affected the class because the guys were distracted in return. And I can only imagine how the other students surrounding them felt – especially when the talkers were split up – and how they wanted to handle it. It obviously affected her learning too. She never used her worksheet and never completed the problems. She would only write down the answer and circle it, so I knew she wasn't learning the material. It made it really hard to stand by her side and baby her, when she's an adult and in college.

I'd say, split people up who are friends in the class. PAL is more of an open discussion setting, and if you have people

who are close, they're going to get off task easier and you don't want that.

-MANDY

"I had some particular students who would answer a question, and start out with a good answer, but drag it on and keep going with it, trying to explain things. As much as you want to encourage students to talk, there's a point when you just want to cut them off. They got their point across and now they're just rambling.

I knew who those students were so when different students would raise their hands, I would call on them first to give them an opportunity to talk. I would call on the others too, but I just wanted to be aware of them. I had to cut them off a couple times but I tried to do so politely. I would say, "Okay, yup, that's good. Anybody else?" Or I would say, "We can talk about that more afterwards."

-BETH

"This particular professor had a very different way of teaching and weird teaching methods. The class was always a week behind because he would teach something, but then he would want them to go back and work on stuff from the week before. I had to make two different lesson plans for my two different sessions because he wanted to be a week behind.

The students just didn't understand. The professor didn't really teach – he would put stuff on the board and say, "OK, go to." The students never had a grasp on what he was

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doing. Ever. They would say, “He doesn’t explain anything,” which is understandable as I attended the lectures myself and thought they were super confusing. If I hadn’t known what was going on already, I would have reacted the same way.

So my students would complain about that. I didn’t participate in their complaining – just because I don’t think that’s ethical from my point – but I would say, “You know guys, I understand, but you’re going to have to deal with these kinds of professors throughout your college career. That’s part of college. You’re not going to like or understand every professor you have.”

I related it to my own experiences when I took this class. I had a professor that I couldn’t understand for the first two

*“I told them ...
‘You’re not in high
school; there’s
not somebody
here to hold your
hand.’”*

weeks of class until I developed an ear for his dialect. I told them that I didn’t know what he was saying, and I could barely read his writing. But I told them, “It’s just something you have to overcome. You’re not in high school; there’s not somebody here to hold your hand. You just have to develop your own way to get around it.” That helped, and once they realized I wasn’t going to sit there and talk about their professor with them, they laid off.

-KELLEY

“I had one student who used to bring his laptop to the session. He said he used it to take notes. Sometimes I’d have him work in

a group on a worksheet, and he would bring the laptop out and start typing. I'd go over and say, "What are you doing?" He'd say, "Oh, I'm just working on the worksheet. I'm typing it up."

Every once in a while then, I'd walk around the room and would make sure to walk behind him. I usually have my students sit in just the first few rows. A couple times I noticed that he was on Facebook – a typical college student. To deal with it, I showed him I was onto him. I'd say, "Could you get off Facebook? This really isn't an appropriate time." Other times, if his group had finished their worksheet before everyone else, I'd say, "Okay class, if I'm working with another group and you have questions, feel free to ask _____. Clearly, he is finished and understands the material because he is on Facebook."

I was using sarcasm and humor to bring it to everyone's attention. Everyone would laugh about it, but the student would get the message: don't be on Facebook during the time when I'm facilitating this section.

-SOO

"I have a whiner in my PAL session right now. She just cries about stupid little injustices. For example, we were playing this game – it was Political Science Review Connect Four – and apparently I was totally siding with the other team by giving them extra time and helping them more with the answers. I was like, "What? Uhh, okay." So I took her side, and I decided to try and help her team out. I gave them extra time the next turn and nudged them towards the answer a little bit, and she still complained! I was thinking, "Okay, you're obviously

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complaining just to complain, so I'm not going to help you anymore."

That was the worst she's ever been. She likes to complain about small things. She'll bring the wrong book occasionally, and she just whines. It's kind of distracting, but it doesn't really have a huge impact. As long as you deal with it in a mature manner, you can just sidestep it and continue on with the material. It shouldn't affect an experienced facilitator, but it might throw a new facilitator off.

You should not completely ignore it. Ask them if there is anything you can do, and take reasonable steps to help them. If they stop complaining, good! You've fixed the problem. If they continue complaining and it's unreasonable, you're not going to be able to satisfy them, so you need to ask them to please stop complaining and continue on. Don't dwell on it. That's very important. Don't make it into a big deal. You want to nip it in the bud, and then move on and concentrate on the material. Students aren't there to listen to someone argue with the facilitator. They're there to do PAL.

-HARRISON

"Every once in a while there are students who sleep in the back of the room. The one that I really remember was from the first semester I was doing PAL.

He always finished his worksheet and then slept. I was like, "Well...okay." I'd just let him sleep. I mean, I was a sophomore at the time, and it was scary. I think he was older than me in grade. I was like, "What do I do with this guy?" I figured as long as he would do his work, I'd let him sleep.

Now, I wouldn't do that. If people aren't participating, make sure they get up, move to a group and start interacting.

-SHANNON

In almost all of my sessions, the topic of professors came up at one point or another – the students thought the professor did a bad job teaching, a bad job grading, wasn't consistent, was hard to understand, didn't write clearly on the board. Whatever the problem was, someone would address it and the rest of the class would join in. If I didn't contain that conversation and end it, it would have gone on for the whole 50 minutes.

The first time it occurred, the conversation went on for a good ten minutes. I had the same opinions as the students – I didn't put in my feedback – but listening, I could relate and understand. Whether you relate or not, the topic of the professor and teaching staff shouldn't be allowed. I realized that I should be more in charge of the conversations brought into my session. It degrades the professor, and it allows the students to come up with excuses. If the students don't understand the material or aren't doing well, now they can say, "Well, we already discussed this. The professor is inconsistent, the professor this, the professor that," rather than focusing on what they can do to learn better and not blaming it on someone else.

I would say to drop that conversation immediately when students are talking about it, because they can branch off so far. Everybody has a negative something to say. Thirty negatives can lead to a bunch of chaos.

-MANDY

"I was facilitating for Chem 1015. The session was required for students, and it was right after their lecture. I had nine students in my session. Three of them were great: they wanted to be there, got the chemistry and wanted to work together. Three of them were somewhere in the middle: they didn't really want to be there, but they understood the chemistry. They would probably rather be doing something else, but they put up with me. The rest, however, could have cared less. They didn't want to be there, period. They weren't interested in what I had to say

"She was the I'm-not-paying-attention-to-you-but-I'm-going-to-ask-a-ton-of-questions-because-I'm-not-sure-what-we're-doing type."

and they weren't interested in what anyone else had to say. They either didn't want to take chemistry, or if they did, they thought they could do it better by themselves.

I had this problem where one of the girls in particular would always show up late, which I could never understand because she came from the lecture room down the hallway with everyone else. She would sit in class, act disinterested

the entire time, and not follow along. She'd constantly say, "What are we doing? Wait, what?" She was the I'm-not-paying-attention-to-you-but-I'm-going-to-ask-a-ton-of-questions-because-I'm-not-sure-what-we're-doing type.

Then she started taking phone calls. She would text on it, then it would ring and she would answer it. She'd say, "Excuse me, I have to take this," and walk outside. The first time it happened I thought, "Okay, maybe it's an emergency," but

then it happened more than once and I knew that she was simply taking calls to get out of class.

She also started leaving early with excuses like, “I have something to be at and I need time to eat dinner.” There were other people in the class who had the same obligations, and they stayed until the end. It became a problem because she started a trend of people wanting to leave early.

I asked the whole class – I didn’t single her out – to focus some more. I said, “We’re here for an hour and 15 minutes, less if we get our work done. You guys know the drill, and I’d appreciate if you weren’t on your computers looking at other things, if you didn’t text and if you didn’t make phone calls. The more you focus on what you’re doing, the less time you’ll be here. If we get through everything I have planned, I’m not going to make you stay.”

I think she stopped coming – which solved the problem – but if I were to redo the situation, I would have made sure those ground rules were laid out in the beginning.

-ABBY

What do you think?

- At what point do you feel it is okay to take an authoritative role in your class?
- Why do we oftentimes feel intimidated to exercise authority over our peers? Why might it be difficult?
- What are some things to be mindful of when asserting your position?

Chapter 6: How Am I Doing?

Being a PAL facilitator often times doesn't feel like a job; it feels like you're taking another class. You attend lecture, stay up-to-date with the class readings, complete the problems (if necessary), and work in groups with other students.

As in any other class, you start to wonder how you're doing midway through. The same is true of facilitating. And while your supervisors are the people in charge of evaluating you, your students very quickly become the ones you aim to please. It's only natural that we want to know whether or not our hard work is helping them succeed.

Some feedback, like the exuberant hug Kelley receives, is explicit, while other types of feedback may be more subtle, such as Harrison's internal excitement when a quiet student finally speaks out – and with a correct answer, no less. It's not always ideal feedback though, as Erin finds out in an empty classroom.

Feedback comes in a variety of forms, but no matter the delivery, the student response is often the most powerful tool in evaluating ourselves and a strong motivator to keep working hard. As you facilitate, ask yourself – and ask your students – “How am I doing?”

-Lana

“ At the beginning of the year, you see students who are shy or just prefer to work by themselves. I used to work like that too, so I know where they are coming from.

Sometimes you don't want to be bothered; you just want to do your work. So in order to have them work together on activities, at first, you have to force them. “Could you join this group?” or “What's your contribution to the group so far?” You have to nudge them along until they get to a point where they don't have to be nudged anymore.

You start to see that they're actively joining groups. They're actively participating, and they're suggesting answers in the larger group – something that they've never done before. That's when I realize, “Okay, this is working.”

The students are going to use those skills later on in upper level classes and life in general, making sure their voices are heard. That's something I tend to stress in PAL sessions – the students have to become independent. They have to look out for themselves. And it's not bad to ask for help in doing that.

-SOO

“This semester I'm facilitating Calculus 1. We start at 3:30 p.m. and work until 4:30 p.m. It always happens that 4:30 comes and 4:30 goes, and the students are still working on the problems. I just hate to interrupt. I'm like, “Okay guys, it's 4:30 and we have to go.” I say that and they're like, “Aww, do we really have to go?” It's interesting to see their desire to be there. They really get into PAL and the ideas it's based on.

As a facilitator, when you see those sorts of reactions, it just gives you such a sense of accomplishment. It's like, I'm

really doing my job well or the students really enjoy coming to sessions. It motivates you to do more and to continually raise the bar for yourself to make sessions better. That's what I take away from moments like those.

-JERED

"In empirically focused classes, compared to the humanities classes, there's a much different threshold for what makes an activity successful. The success of empirically-based classes seems to relate to the situation when one student understands the material – the light bulb turns on – and then they help their peers with it. They'll help their peers because they want to almost show off that they know the material.

I made a lot of worksheets in a class like this, and one particular student, who was normally very quiet, understood standard deviation and how to compute it right away. She got it and explained it to one other student for probably 20 minutes or so. You could see that second student start to understand and help others as well.

That was one of the sessions that I didn't have to do very much, and the students took care of it themselves. It's nice to know that you can design a worksheet that helps students learn and that when they do get the point of the worksheet, it works for them. That's really cool.

-JEFF

"I had a 50-year old student. She hadn't taken algebra since high school – however many years ago that was – so she struggled.

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She only went to college for a little while, and she didn't take math then. She was coming back.

She was having so many problems right from the start. It was the second week of class and she was already struggling with material. I helped her a lot individually in class because she couldn't keep up with the groups and you know, she was holding them back a little bit. When the first test came, she was so nervous for it because she didn't understand any of the material and it was all review – things students should know from high school. On top of that, it was a take home test, but she was still so nervous.

She brought her test back to me the next week, and she got an A on it! She was so excited and gave me this really big hug. It was kind of uncomfortable, but then I was like, "Well, you're kind of like my mom, so it's fine." She was

"She said, 'Oh my gosh, I wouldn't have been able to do this without you!'"

just so excited and said, "Oh my gosh, I wouldn't have been able to do this without you!" She stood up in front of the class and told me all this really loudly, so everyone could hear her. It was really funny, and the whole class ended up clapping for her.

-KELLEY

"We were doing Lewis structures in my chemistry session and it was at the "ah ha" point in the semester that the students were either really going to like chemistry or not like it at all. There was one girl who had been really struggling all class. I can't

remember what I told her, but I just gave her a couple of pointers and walked away to the next group. All of a sudden, I heard her say, "OH! I get it!!" It was perfect.

It's definitely rewarding. You go in week after week, and you want your students to leave with something. They leave week after week and you don't know if they've been learning anything. Then they have days when they go, "I get it!" and you're like, "Really? Good, that's amazing! Thank you for making this worthwhile."

-ABBY

"At the end of the semester, a group of my students asked if I would go out to dinner with them as a thank you for being their facilitator. I thought about it, and I was worried about whether it was wrong or not to go. I decided to go – it was the end of the semester anyways, so I was technically done with them. It was actually nice because they talked about things like different teaching methods I had used that they thought were good and bad – it was beneficial to hear their feedback. They were more willing to give it in a less formal situation.

Our conversation was mostly focused on architecture and the PAL program, but they were all international students as well so it was really interesting to talk to them about their cultures. They talked about different learning styles, which was valuable. They explained that in China, where most of them were from, raising your hand is like being a show-off. So that's why when I had been asking questions, no one would volunteer. In their culture, that was the good thing to do. A lot of things

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they told me I would not have learned if I hadn't spent that time with them.

I did end up working with a couple of the students the next semester and I think the experience helped with our PAL relationship. Those students were more willing to email me, ask me questions, and just work with me more. They were less afraid to approach me and thought of me as a peer, which is a goal of being a facilitator.

-BETH

"I had been having sessions for five or six weeks, and the students always participated, but they weren't very enthusiastic. One week, they were all working really hard. It was the week after they had had an exam and I was kind of surprised because in the past, everyone had gotten burnt out by the exams; the next week they usually want to relax and put off learning the new material.

I was really confused as to why they were working so hard, but it made for a great session. We did a study guide and shared answers in groups. At the end, I gave a post-exam survey. I try to do that at least once a semester. The first two questions are always pretty interesting. The first one is, "When you walked into the test, how confident were you?" and then there is a scale from 1 to 5, from not confident at all to very confident. The next question is, "After finding out how you scored, how satisfied were you?" In this group, I noticed that they all walked in very confident and that their scores were not very satisfying. There were lots of 5s in the confidence and 1s and 2s in the satisfaction.

Some of the other questions talk about studying habits - what they did to prepare and how many lectures they missed - and then the last questions are about the PAL sessions specifically.

The feedback that I received was overwhelmingly positive. They all said everything was perfect and that everything should be kept the way it is because it helped them on the exam. They wrote, "Now I realize how important it is to be here" and basically, "You do know what you're talking about." Some of the comments were really nice, and I still have every survey I've ever given out. I guess when I start questioning whether they see the value in PAL or whether they respect me as a facilitator, I can look back at those surveys and say, "You know Jeanna, you helped some students along the way."

Now though, I have started trying to be more of a realist with students at the start of the semester. I say, "This is a hard class. People fail these tests and I don't want that to be you." I even say, "I'm not trying to scare you off but I want you to realize now, sooner rather than later, that you need to study, put in the time and read every word of the textbook that's assigned." Seeing that my students were more confident than they should have been has led me to give better advice to other students about how much to study. Some of them were very confident after studying for two hours, which isn't enough.

-JEANNA

Two (Or More) Heads Are Better Than One

“Last fall semester, in the last day of PAL, I thanked the students for coming to class, participating, studying and asking questions. They were really good students like that. I told them good-bye and said, “I’ve been glad to work with you and help you.” One student got sensitive and emotional. Her eyes turned red, and she kept crying when I said, “This the last day, and I feel lucky that I could work with you. I hope everything I’ve done has helped you. If I did something wrong, please forgive me.” I said something like that, and she got really emotional.

The students had some connection with me, and they liked me being their PAL facilitator. It was helpful for them. I felt the connection especially in that class where the attendance didn’t count. They came because they wanted to learn. If they don’t feel like it’s helpful, they won’t come to it. So, it gave me some idea that I can do something good for them and interest them.

-ANH

“There was a student in my Anthropology 1001 session who really, really struggled. This student was not academically oriented and was trying to decide whether college was the right place for him. We’d talked a little bit about that.

One day, right before a test, we were having a review session. He’d been really quiet the entire review and then I asked a question that nobody else knew the answer to. His hand shot up and he just NAILED it! He was so happy, and it was really rewarding to see him knock it out of the park. That was awesome!

It's a huge confidence builder to see that I'm getting through to the students in my sessions. It obviously makes me feel very good.

-HARRISON

"I was doing some extra sessions for athletes so I would go to the athletic center for three or four sessions throughout the

*"I got there about
15 minutes early, I
waited and no one
came."*

semester just before tests. I'd had some of these sessions already, and usually about four or five athletes showed up. This was the last session that I would be having with them, and it was a session in preparation for the final.

So I prepared for a rush – at least 10 people which would be double what I normally have. I got there about 15 minutes early, I waited and no one came. I waited at least 15 or 20 minutes after the session was supposed to start. I checked with the office to see if I was in the right room, I checked my email at a kiosk to see if I had the right room, and I just wandered around the building. I ended wasting 45 minutes, and no one came.

It was kind of hard for me because it was my first semester doing PAL, and I was still fairly new. I had worked with these students two or three times before – in a way, I was kind of personally hurt that they didn't come. I thought they had found it useful, and now this was before the final. Why wouldn't they come? The department had scheduled the session to fit

Two (Or More) Heads Are Better Than One

around the athletes' schedule. I don't know what happened. I guess I just had to buck up after that and not take it personally.

-ERIN

"We were doing an exam review once, and the exams in this particular class were based primarily on short-answer essay questions. We did a lot of predicting test questions: what kind of terms do you need to know? What do you need to know about them? How much information should you write?

For the essay questions, we brainstormed a couple essay prompts, chose one of them and outlined very quickly the arguments for it. We did it in less than five minutes; it was something that the students could do within the actual exam time so they would have a structure to keep them in focus without taking too long.

The session afterwards, I asked the students, "How did it go? Did anything come up that was surprising? What went well?" They told me that the essay prompt that we picked the previous week was one of the essay options, so they all wrote the exact same essay because they knew what to write. They were so happy! I couldn't stop smiling for the rest of the day because of how effectively I managed to help each of them that time. It was a very direct effect of PAL.

-SOO

"On the first day of PAL, I put my name, email address and phone number up on the board. Some people write it down. Some people actually put my phone number in their phones

immediately, and I always just assume that no one is actually going to use it. The past two semesters though, I've had people call me up before tests or when they're in study groups and say, "Hey Jeanna, I have a quick question. Is it okay if I put you on speakerphone? There are five or six other people here that I'm studying with, and we really just don't understand this."

Sometimes I can answer their question right away. Other times – I mean, I want to be careful not to overstep the line between being a PAL facilitator and being a TA who can directly answer their questions. So if I'm not by my book, I'll usually just say, "Well, I'm busy, but I can call you back later." Then I can kind of point them to where they should be in the book and show them the passage they should look at.

Other people that have been in these speakerphone sessions have actually asked if they could come to PAL, so that really makes me feel good about the work that I'm doing and the fact that these people see me as a valuable resource.

At the end of last semester, before the final, this one student kept texting me questions – which is fine, I actually prefer that. I was answering them back pretty short, for example, "Go to page 271." Over Christmas break, this student found out his grade and he texted me. He was like, "I aced Psych dude! Yeah!" I said, "Oh, that's awesome. Good job!" He texted me back and said, "You were my only TA that I've ever actually liked." As much as you say the I'm-a-facilitator-not-a-TA thing, they usually just stick with, "You're my TA." But it was fine, and that meant a lot to me.

-JEANNA

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What do you think?

- What do you specifically want to know from your students?
- What nonverbal feedback can you pick up on?
- How can you use the feedback in planning and conducting your sessions?

Chapter 7:

Preparation

■ Prepare for your session. Seems simple, right?

■ Perhaps more than any topic, stories of preparation usually seem to be about mishaps instead of success. When you prepare well and things go smoothly, well it just doesn't make for a good story. The opposite case, however, always makes for some memorable moments. And, for the most part, it only takes one instance of ill preparation for facilitators to learn a lesson (take note of how many of the stories conclude with a statement along the lines of "never again...").

■ There's a reason this chapter is not called "Being Unprepared," and that's because it's not always a lack of preparation that gets facilitators into trouble, but sometimes it's over preparation or mis-preparation.

■ Remember, just when you think you're ready to go, try explaining a concept to someone else. You might just find the need to brush up yourself. Read on and take notes!

-Lana

“ It was my second semester of facilitating short calculus. I walked into my session, started leading PAL, and realized that the students were a couple days ahead in lecture than what I had prepared. After we had covered all the sections, the students asked me, “Well, what about section 3.6?”

“Oh, have you covered that already?”

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"Yeah we have homework due on that section in two days."

"Have you tried any of the homework yet?"

"No."

"Okay, that's good. We won't start on it now because you haven't started thinking about it yet. We'll just move past that section, and I think you'll be able to cover it if you use your book and your notes. You can always ask your TA if you find you have problems with it."

I completely ignored the section; I didn't cover it. The next week, I didn't cover it. I didn't know they were going to be covering that section, and I hadn't reviewed it. The first semester's class didn't cover that section. That's why I have never prepared for it. So second semester when they covered it, I was very surprised and thrown off guard. I was not ready or comfortable with the material.

We just ignored it, and the students were fine with that. They didn't question me at all. I think if I would have tried to cover that subject, it would have been a crash and burn. I would have been reading the book to try and figure it out, and the students would have been sitting there wasting time. I'm glad I didn't try to do it.

I told them: "I have a whole hour's worth of material here already, so let's focus on this and if you get done early, maybe we can try and figure it out together." But we didn't finish early, so it was fine.

-ALICIA

“Okay, this is so embarrassing.

I had been facilitating for, like, two years and I don’t know what I was thinking – I just printed off the wrong worksheet! I had made sheets in the past, and I usually just tweaked them from semester to semester. So I went to my session and said, “All right, this is what we’re going to be doing this week.” The students looked at me and said, “We did that last week.”

“What?”

“Yeah, they’re a little different, but we did this last week.”

“What week are we in? Week 11?”

“No, we’re in week 12.”

“Ohhh...”

So I quickly opened my book and randomly picked five problems from the book that they could work on. I told them to work on their homework for a little bit, while I got problems arranged. I think they thought I was going crazy, but it was okay in the end. I think we probably only wasted 10-15 minutes of PAL.

The students were fine, but I felt really dumb. It never happened again, let me just say that. I carefully double-check!

-KELLEY

“Once, I had a really big test the morning of my PAL sessions, and so all I did to prepare was pick the questions and write down the answers. I’d facilitated the class before so I knew how to do the problems, but I didn’t specifically work through them that time around. I thought, “Oh, I’ll be fine.”

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I was also in a really bad mood when I got to my session because I thought I'd failed that morning's test. The students would ask me questions, and I'd have to go back to my seat and do the problem. By the time I'd get back to them, the students would have moved on. It went really badly because it felt so

"Even if you know the general idea of problems, students will still have that one little question."

chaotic. Even if you know the general idea of problems, students will still have one little question that makes you go, "Oh, well usually you do it like this ... but maybe it doesn't apply to that one. Let me check."

I just didn't like the feeling that I couldn't handle the situation right away; I would have to go figure it out for five minutes – or just a minute, but still. I would definitely not go into a session like that ever again – and I never did. It felt terrible.

So I over-prepared from then on in that class. Even so, the session had less attendance after that day. I felt they didn't respect me as much. Something about it – maybe the fact that they always wanted the answers from me – something was different than in my other classes. I felt that whenever I wouldn't give them answers, they thought I didn't do it, when in reality, I wasn't giving them answers because that's not what I'm there for. It was like they were challenging me.

They were a morning class, so that could've played a role. It could've been a result of anything, but it felt like it was a result of that instance.

-MICHELLE

“It was my first semester doing PAL, about three weeks in. I lived in Comstock Hall at the time, and my sessions were in Ford Hall, not too far away. This was a semester when I was making worksheets, and it was a voluntary session; I think I only had about four students in that particular one. I had two sessions though, and they were back-to-back. I got to the first one, started the students on their work, and began going through my papers. It was then I realized I had forgotten the answer key. I knew I made it, but it wasn’t in my bag; it was in my dorm room.

I decided the best thing, instead of trying to flounder around for two sessions, would be to go get it. I was a sophomore and a lot of the students were either sophomores or freshmen, kind of the same age. They seemed mature enough to leave alone for a few minutes. I asked the students if they would be okay to stay there and keep working, and I would run back to my dorm room and be back. And I did! I ran back the whole way, found it immediately – thank goodness – and ran back. I think I only missed about ten minutes, and they were working the whole time. Nonetheless, it taught me to always check that you have your things!

I was prepared in that I had made the answer sheet, but obviously it’s no good if you don’t have it with you. I probably could have worked through it because I knew the material, but being that it was my first semester doing PAL, I was really nervous. I did not forget it again.

-ERIN

“My architecture sessions are voluntary so students don’t always come, but one particular girl came regularly. I would mention a

building and the person who built it for example, and she would say, “Oh, I didn’t think he did that one.” Everything I would say, I would get an, “Are you sure?” I couldn’t tell if she didn’t trust my answers or was just inquisitive and wanted to know more.

I started keeping my laptop open and on the Internet, ready to go every time. When she would say, “He didn’t design that,” I could look it up and say, “Oh yeah, here it is. He did.” It was a matter of finding a way to connect to her and helping her to look it up herself. That way, when she asked these questions on her own, she would know where to look.

She could trust that I was doing my work. I just made sure to address it right away and not argue with her, but have a source ready to show her. I knew she would ask, so I came prepared for it.

-BETH

“I was never unprepared. I always made a worksheet for my sessions, and I always had material to discuss. I even had extra materials and problems if we got done with things early. I would say I was always well-prepared.

It was me not fully understanding the concepts on the problems that caused trouble. I’d be a little iffy on some things, and I’d have to make references to the book. I could figure it out, but I just wasn’t as good at it as I could have been.

Sometimes though, I wouldn’t understand a problem, but I’d still put it on the worksheet because there was a similar example in the book. I liked doing that because it made the students feel like I didn’t always have the answer – how hard can they work to come up with it? When teachers don’t know

the answer, it allows for more real discussion. If the students feel they really do need to contribute because *you* don't even know the answer, it will really push them. Even if you do know all the answers, sometimes it's a good strategy to pretend otherwise. They think: "My teacher doesn't know this; I'm going to show her I can do it."

It has to be in a strategic sense though; you can't be unable to do a lot of the problems. If there's one or two that

"If you're dealing with something you're completely clueless about, what happens when everyone else is too?"

you're unsure of but you have a really well-laid out book example that's similar to it, you can figure it out and it can also be a good lesson for students.

But if you just throw things together and have no solutions worked out, you're going to be unprepared. If you're dealing with something you're completely clueless about, what happens when

everyone else is too? Do you say, "We're going to skip this one"? No.

-MANDY

"We had actually finished doing an activity way ahead of schedule, and I didn't know what to do with the rest of the time. I didn't have anything prepared; I had planned on my activity taking up the whole session. I wasn't going to let the students go because then I wouldn't be using their time effectively, so I asked them what they wanted to do. This particular group had

some jokesters, and a bunch of them piped up, “Well, what math class are you in, like, Calc 10?” I joked back, saying, “No, I’m way past that.”

So they asked to see something from a different calculus course, and I thought, “Okay, yeah, I can do that and show them a little of what we do in higher mathematics.”

I decided to do a Calc 4 problem with no preparation, no nothing. But I was like, “Okay, it’s Calc 4, I do this all the time.” I set it up on the board, and it just failed miserably. I didn’t know how to do it! They pulled it totally out of left field on me.

The students were asking questions like, “What are these symbols?” I could answer those questions, so they did learn some notation out of it, but it’s just the fact I wasn’t prepared for it. It’s something I know I’ll never do again. I will either have more materials planned for a lesson or make something up on a whim that’s related to *their* studies, instead of *my* studies.

-JERED

“The class was talking about resonance, which is a way of looking at molecules. There are rules for how you draw these structures. I gave the students a problem, they worked through it, and when we got to discussing it, I noticed my answer was different than theirs. So, of course, I say to them, “I’m not sure that yours is quite right. Let’s talk about it and think about it.”

They started explaining it to me and were talking about this concept that I hadn’t even heard of – they said their professor talked about it though. Someone had a textbook, and I

looked it up. Sure enough, it turns out they were right, but it was just something that my professor hadn't taught when I took the class.

We ended up having a good discussion out of that, but it was another reminder that I'm not a TA, but a facilitator – I'm not infallible. Even though it was something that I was unprepared for, having the students explain it to me was another learning experience. I think they left understanding that concept more, and I even learned something.

I did feel worried about losing the students' confidence in me after that session, not because anyone said anything to make me feel that way, but more because of my own pride. Even though you're not teaching things, you want to come in prepared. You don't want to give students any reason to question whether you know what you're doing. There weren't any behavioral issues that spawned from that, so that's good. I think we all learned that we could talk it over, and in the end, they would understand the material.

-ERIN

"Probability was very hard for me to grasp when I was took the College Algebra class, so to turn around and facilitate it was really challenging. The first few semesters I was doing PAL, I would come to the session with a worksheet prepared where I thought I understood how to do all the probability problems. But when it came down to actually explaining them to a student, I would get all jumbled in my own thoughts. It was harder than I anticipated.

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At that point, students would get frustrated. The best that I could do at the end of the day was say, “I’m not a math major. I will try hard to be able to answer this question more thoroughly next week once I’ve looked at it further.” Beyond that, it was just a goal of mine to never come to class unprepared again or to at least choose problems I was comfortable with and that I knew how to do step-by-step.

This material is really frustrating, and I can understand that coming to my classroom – where the material is supposed to become clearer and it doesn’t – is just more frustrating and even furthers the students’ hatred towards the material. I think the attitude of the students in this case was, “Well if she doesn’t know how to do it, why should I know how?”

I don’t think I ever really lost the students’ trust. I said, “I’m sorry I don’t know how to explain this today, but we’ll come back to it.” As the weeks went on, I got a better grasp on the section again, but if it got to a point where I honestly didn’t have a clue how to explain it any further, I’d tell students to ask their professor, ask their TA, go to the SMART Learning Commons, etc. Especially with probability, I’d make reference towards their book as well.

-SHANNON

“I was going to have my students use old tests to make up study guides for their final, which was cumulative. I always keep my old tests in my folder, and I guess I just assumed that all my students did too. I was wrong because only four or five out of 15 students had the tests.

I ended up breaking them into groups and making sure that someone with a test was in each group. Then they could look off of one person's test to come up with the problems for their study guide.

What I learned is that if you want students to bring something, make sure you email them and let them know. I realized I have to remember that my students don't all have the same study skills that I do. You have to be flexible, which I ran into a lot since my session was voluntary. I make 10 copies of my handouts every week, and normally eight people attend. Once in a while though, there are more and I just have to figure out a way to go with it. Work in partners on a worksheet instead.

-BETH

"I came to PAL this semester with this really cool plan for the session in Political Science 1001. We were going to make research studies and design them all class period – what are the aspects of a good study? What are the aspects of a bad study? Design a study for this, this and this.

For an upperclassman, this comes really quickly, but I didn't realize how little experience these freshman and sophomores would have with this. So they just looked at me like deer in headlights. I didn't know what to do because my whole session was based around this really complex activity.

I tried to improv some things on the spot and I think it probably shook their faith in me,

"They just looked at me like deer in headlights."

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because it was right in the beginning of the semester. Maybe if it hadn't been, I would've been a little more alerted to where they were intellectually. I could totally feel them looking at me thinking, "Okay, does he know anything about political science or what he's doing?"

As long as you don't do something like that every time though, your students are going to trust you again. I just made the next session doable, but still difficult so they respected my knowledge of political science. You can increase the difficulty so they have to rely on you a little more. As the semester continues, you start to see their competence come out. They won't need you as much so they'll depend on each other.

The lesson learned in this case is to get to know your students before you throw them a curveball. Leave that towards the end.

-HARRISON

"I was facilitating Math 1031, so it was College Algebra and Probability. We had been through the whole semester of College Algebra and I really liked my group of kids – I knew all their names, they worked great in their groups, everything was fine. We got to the probability unit and I thought, "I want to make this fun. I'm going to make a slideshow." So I made a slideshow of the problems.

I projected them up on the screen, and the students worked on them one at a time without worrying about getting through a whole sheet. We got to one of the last problems, which I had no idea how to solve the problem, but the teacher had given me a solution. I knew the answer – it was written out for

me – but I had no idea how the professor came up with it. I just assumed that the students, who had been practicing this, knew how to do it. That's why I had added it to the slideshow with the rest of the problems. We got to this one and I thought, "I hope someone figures it out."

They started working through it, and everyone had questions. They just stared blankly and I said, "Does anyone know how to do this problem?" Nobody knew. So I stood up at the whiteboard and showed them the answer according to their teacher. I asked them if they could see where the parts of the answer came from and figure it out backwards. Nobody knew. So I said, "That's okay, because I don't know either, so let's hope they don't put one like this on the test!"

Pretty much, I told the students that I didn't know how to do it, and they were really respectful of that. They wished I could have explained it, but we just moved past it. I told them it was a really difficult example and that the teacher would probably give them a different counting cards problem. It wasn't fun, but we got through it.

Because it was the end of the semester, and it was such a difficult problem, I think the students were okay with the fact that I didn't know how to do it. Some weeks, I made mistakes on their worksheets. For example, on a test review, I made multiple-choice problems and then forgot to put in the right answer, or I solved it wrong or forgot a negative sign or something. They would correct me on little mistakes. They knew I knew what was going on and I could explain it, but they were also comfortable enough to check my work and tell me when I made a mistake. They knew I was knowledgeable, but this was one thing I just didn't know.

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I definitely don't ever put problems in our sessions that I don't know how to do anymore. I always know how to do it or look at a solutions manual to figure out how to do it.

-ALICIA

"I was the first person in our program to facilitate Organic Chemistry I, so I had no previous material to work with. I made worksheets for each session. When it came time for the first exam, I decided to write up a practice exam. The professor I was supporting didn't have any practice exams on his website, so all I had were problems from the book and my own past exams. I had a different professor, so those weren't extremely useful.

I spent hours writing up an exam attempting to cover all the necessary material, using one or two problems of each type. I used a few problems from the book, but some of them we had already done, so I had to think of different molecules to use. I also had to teach myself to use a computer program that drew the molecules. The document ended up being about five pages, in addition to a similarly long answer key.

I went to the session, and we barely got through one page during the 50 minutes. I went home feeling defeated. It was such a waste of time for me to make this exam, even though the students had this great resource. From then on, I decided to just review a few key concepts on a normal length worksheet. Even if the problems were ones we had already worked through, it would still be good practice for the students. In subsequent semesters, the professors have had practice exams available, so I've tried to take advantage of those as much as possible too.

-ERIN

What do you think?

- What resources are available to use when preparing for your sessions?
- What might make preparing a challenge for you?
- Worse-case scenario: you're unprepared or your plan is a bust. What is your back-up plan?
- How will you handle being stumped by the course content or by a student's questions?

Chapter 8: When the Unexpected Happens

■ Attended lecture? Check. Read the material? Check.
■ Understood it? Check. Prepared a session plan? Check. Brought the answer key? Check.

■ Good, thorough preparation can make your sessions smooth, beneficial and enjoyable. And you've read what can happen when preparation attempts are too little or too late. But, in some cases, no amount of preparation can ready you for the curveballs that inevitably come up. Faulty technology, off-the-wall questions, and – good grief! – tantrums in class?! Yes, just to name a few.

■ As you read through these stories, you'll see that some facilitators were able to rally on the spot when faced with the unforeseen. Others opted – perhaps out of shock – to simply let the chips fall where they may, as my mother always says. No one can instruct you on *what* to do when the unexpected happens; I can only assure you that, occasionally, it does.

-Lana

“ I know there have been times where I've had a math problem on my worksheet, had the steps to complete the problem, and it turns out that it isn't right. There would be questions flying from every direction in the session. “Why'd you do that?” “How'd you get that?” When it's happening, it's overwhelming and you don't know what to say. I can't remember exactly why I chose those steps or not!

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Typically when I'm in that situation I'll say, "Well let me look at it again. We'll talk about it next week." It'll give me more time to think it over and determine whether I have the right answer or the students have the right answer. And if I'm wrong, I'll say it. I'll admit I was wrong and use it as an example. "This is where I went wrong and you can see the steps that were mistakes."

If it was my fault that a problem was confusing, I'll apologize. Obviously, I'm not perfect. The most I can do is to show them the right answer, whether it's that minute or the next week.

-SHANNON

"I've had students ask me questions out of the book that I tried to solve right in front of them and didn't know how to do; I was trying to solve it on the fly. And so I learned very quickly never to do that again. Now what I do is I always have two or three practice problems from every section written down, so when they say, "I don't know how to do this. Can we do a practice one?" I get to pick one that I know how to solve. They don't get to pick. Then I can confidently show them how it goes. It was really uncomfortable to not know how to do a problem and have them look at me and say, "So what do we do?"

"I don't know. This is what I got, but it doesn't look right, so...I guess that was a bad problem."

"What if they give us one like that on the test?"

"I hope that they don't." I didn't know how to comfort them and it was not pretty. If I don't know how to do it, I've often said, "Maybe you should ask your TA how to solve this

one.” If they have a question about a certain subject, I don’t normally direct them to one classmate, but I have the whole group come together. I’ll say, “Hey, we had a question about Section 4.1. Let’s go over it really quick.” Then we’ll summarize it together and normally do one example, which I now know that I should prepare. It would have been a good idea if I had redirected them to a different student who might have said they’d done something similar in the homework.

-ALICIA

“My sessions started at 10:10, and I typically went to the lectures right before. One day, my alarm clock did not go off. I got up and it was 10 o’ clock! With the amount of time I had, there was no way I could get to campus by 10:10. I went as soon as I could, and I remember finally making my way towards my classroom and seeing two of my students walking down the hall. They were way too far away for me to start yelling across the entire hallway to them. I’m just thinking, “I wonder where they’re going...” It didn’t dawn on me that students would leave after only 5 minutes!

I continued walking and was coming up the stairs when another two of my students passed me. They went, “Oh hey, you’re here!”

“Yeah. Where are going?”

“Well, we’re turning around now!”

So we walked back and there were two students still in the classroom. Apparently I had had all nine or ten of my students, and I ended up working with only four. I went through an

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activity with them the best that I could considering the decrease in students. We covered the material we needed to cover.

The next session, when everyone was there, I apologized and said, "I'm sorry. It was my fault I was late." I acknowledged that and told them I'd do my best to make sure it didn't happen again. At the same time, I explained that they couldn't just leave after five minutes! It's going to happen that professors will be late, and typically there's a certain grace period of 10-15 minutes. I said, "Leaving is at your own risk. Keep in mind that if your professor was late to a lecture and you left, you wouldn't get attendance points for that day. Same thing goes for PAL." I explained that they would all get points for the previous week but that it was the only time.

-SOO

"In my first semester of PAL, I LOVED it. I really enjoyed facilitating. In my second semester though, I had three sessions back-to-back and was getting pretty tired. The first day, in my third session, a guy comes in with a beer. I was like, "Ohhhkay..." I had never seen anyone do that before; it didn't even occur to me that that might happen. So I was kind of shocked, and I didn't know how to deal with it.

He sat in the front corner, and I didn't say anything. I thought, "Well I'll just let it go for now, and if it happens again, I'll approach it." So the next week came around and he brought a six-pack for the other guys in the session. They were all freshmen, and they were loving it because they weren't even old enough to drink. Here they are getting beers handed to them in the middle of a PAL session!

At that point, I asked them to leave. Some of them left; some of them stayed but didn't drink it. I told Mary about the situation, and she came to watch the next week.

Because she was there, the beer – which they did bring

– stayed in the pack. But they decided they needed a smoke break in the middle of my 50-minute session. So they left to go outside for 20 minutes of my 50-minute session. I talked to them after class and told them, "If you're not going to be here for the majority of the class and you can't stay here for the 50 minutes, I'm not going to be able to mark you for attendance." They said, "Oh okay, we can stay here. We'll wait and smoke after."

The next week they didn't go out and smoke, but the main guy decided he would bring his water bottle to chew and spit tobacco. The girls were totally disgusted. It smelt bad, first of all, and it was gross to watch and hear. One girl, who liked to speak her mind, confronted him about it, which made it a lot easier on me. She said she didn't want him to do that; she was trying to learn, he was distracting her, and it was just gross.

After the confrontation, he stopped doing it and he actually shaped up. His participation was bad at the beginning – he didn't want to be there – but he actually opened up to me by the third or fourth week. He was an older student who had been kicked out of his first college and didn't want to be in school; his parents were forcing him to go, and that explained his background.

"They weren't even old enough to drink. Here they are getting beers handed to them in the middle of a PAL session!"

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In the beginning, when it was just the alcohol, people kept quiet and were just shocked that it happened. A couple of the students lived in my dorm, and they would bring it up over dinner like, “Oh my gosh, did you see that guy drinking in the middle of your session? Aren’t you going to do something about it?” The drinking had an impact on the group, but not nearly as much as the guys getting up and walking out of class to smoke or the one student chewing and actually distracting others.

It was definitely hard at first, especially because it was the third session of the day. I was getting tired of doing the same material, back-to-back for three hours. But it also helped me see that bad or unexpected things can happen and you need to be ready for anything.

-LAUREN

“In my first PAL session ever, there was this guy who was SO cute. I had the biggest crush on him. He was in a fraternity where I had a lot of friends. I ended up going to one of their date parties for whatever reason, and somehow, I ended up being set up to go with my student! I tried to explain to my friend, saying, “I can’t do that! I can’t go,” but my friend was like, “It’ll be fine. He has other friends there; he just needs somebody for a date.”

We were friendly by then – I had seen my student a couple of times when I was hanging out at the fraternity with my friends. So it wasn’t uncomfortable that we had gone together, but then later in the night, he proceeded to get all pouty. I said to him, “What is your deal? You’re supposed to be having fun here.” He told me he was so confused because he really liked me, but he loved his girlfriend, on and on and on!

*“You know, I’m your
PAL facilitator; we
aren’t gonna date!”*

I sat him down, and I’m like,
“You know, I’m your PAL
facilitator; we aren’t gonna date!
So you can just let that go and not
worry about it anymore, because
this is not happening!”

After that, I think he got
the point. He still came to PAL, and it wasn’t really awkward. I
think we both just wanted to forget that it had happened.

-SHANNON

“It was my first day of PAL, and I had two sessions in a row. The
first one went fine, and I was on my way to the second one. I had
to go a pretty long distance, so I ran over to the building,
climbed up the stairs to the fourth floor, and I was sweating a lot
– really gross.

I went in, wrote my name and my email address on the
board, turned around, and thought, “These kids all look a lot
older.” I said, “Is this PreCalc?” They were like, “Nooo, this is
actually a graduate class.” I felt super embarrassed, and only
then did I see the classroom change sign on the door. I hadn’t
noticed when I walked in that it was the wrong classroom. It
was already a minute past when the class was supposed to start,
and I had to run across campus again!

I was really late by the time I got there, not to mention,
still sweating and gross; it was just a bad introduction. My
students were all still there, but they were just wondering what
this PAL session was. When I came in, they all thought I was one
of the students, too. I set my bag down on the desk and started

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talking, and they're like, "Wait, are you running this?" It was not a good start!

-DOROTHY

"I had a group of four girls in my anthropology session who came up to me on the 150th anniversary of Darwin's Origin of Species' publication. They brought me a copy of it that people were handing out on campus, just as kind of a nice thing. They didn't mean to do anything wrong here – that's very important. But they gave it to me, and we were talking about it informally after the session when they said, "Do you actually believe in evolution?" I said, "Excuse me? Do you realize what you're asking?"

I don't feel comfortable quoting the conversation because I would horribly mangle it, but the vibe I was getting was that they didn't believe the material that was taught in the course, they didn't understand why it was at all applicable, and they didn't understand how it was scientifically derived. Otherwise, they wouldn't have argued it as much. They were staying in their comfort zone – these particular students were quite religious. One of them alluded to that anyway.

They said some things that were pretty offensive, and it really shook me. I was taking an Intro to Counseling course, and I brought it up to one of my professors. She told me I should talk to them. I was going to make an announcement for the next session, but not all of them came. I wanted to give a quick talk about respect. Evolution is a very charged topic for a lot of people, and you have to be really careful about how you talk

about it. Not all four of them came to a session until three or four weeks later, so it was too far gone to address it.

What I should have done was address it right away – before they even left that day. But I made a mistake there.

-HARRISON

"In one of my PAL sessions, the TA came on the first day. I wrote some problems on the board, and he came up to me and asked, "Are you an undergraduate TA?" He said it like he was in a supervisor role, but I didn't react to that.

I thought that was it, but he came the next three weeks! The second week, he handed back homework to the students who hadn't gone to his session that week – right while we were doing the activity, interrupting the time that the students work together. He should've come to me first – he didn't ask me "Is it okay?" He just did it like it was his session, and that really bothered me.

I think the students were bothered by it too. We usually divide into groups, and the students discuss the problems really well. "How did you do that?" and "Oh, I get that." Then the TA would come and call a name or just walk through and hand out homework. Students would look up and not pay attention to their work. One time, the TA asked a student in my session, "Why weren't you in my class? You come to this session and not mine." He implied something like that, and the student didn't know how to respond.

The next week, he was still doing it. I thought, "I cannot tolerate this anymore." So, in a PAL team meeting, I told the PAL team leader, Jered, "The TA keeps coming to my session every week interrupting it, which I don't feel comfortable with.

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Can you talk to Mary about it?" Mary must've done something about it because I didn't see him in my session after that.

-ANH

What do you think?

- When backup plans fail, what's left to guide you through the session?
- What personal attributes do you possess that will support you when the unexpected happens?
- How might you involve other people or use other resources to deal with an unforeseen situation?

Chapter 9:

Adaptation

As a PAL facilitator, your foremost goal is to make sure learning takes place with your students at the helm. But what does it take to make learning happen? And isn't it different for every student? As you continue to facilitate, it will become clear that every session has a different dynamic: a different pace, energy level, and preference for activities. In fact, every small group will shift in these dynamics...even every student!

I don't say these things to cause panic though. After all, what good would this book be if it only scared you? It's important to be aware of these various dynamics and to try to adapt to them as your students progress. Strive to understand their needs, and stick with what works once you do. Do you notice a few students zoning out and falling asleep when they work on worksheets? Try an interactive game next week to keep their interest. Are a couple people in your 4-person groups fading into the background? Try individual or paired activities to hold them responsible for their work.

Just as students' learning abilities and preferences change, so should your approach to PAL. The following stories show just how important these observations and adaptations can be.

-Lana

“ One semester I had two very different PAL sessions. One was, I’m not going to say smarter, but very focused and didn’t need a lot of help. They cruised through worksheets. With the other session, we never got through half the worksheets because the students didn’t know what was going on with the material. They didn’t know how to do a word problem or even how to start it.

And so I got into the habit of staying after – I didn’t have class afterwards – and it was a mistake. I should have said I had class. I got in the habit of helping students who stayed, and pretty soon, it was half the group. It turned into a 90-minute session instead of a 50-minute one. They weren’t asking about homework; they just didn’t know how to do the worksheet, so we were staying longer to do that.

I didn’t feel like I could say, “Nope. We’re not doing that anymore,” so I just cut the worksheets in half. I only gave them three or four problems, which worked a lot better because then we could do what we had been doing after class, in class. I picked the three most important problems for them to understand, which reduced me staying afterwards.

I didn’t mind helping them out but I clearly distinguished my role as a facilitator, not a teacher. They were still going up to the board, and I still asked them questions to help them along to the answers. I didn’t say, “OK, here’s what you need to do now.” I would ask, “What do you think you should do, and why did you choose that?” “Who thinks something different?” It’s like you’re teaching, but it’s more in a way that gives the students the lead.

-KELLEY

"It was my first semester as a PAL facilitator, and I wasn't entirely comfortable with the content area. It was Biogeography of the Global Garden and kind of outside of my comfort zone. I would just have my students do worksheets, review lecture notes, and work with some of the readings. This one student always sat there silently. I would ask him questions, sometimes singling him out, and he would answer 'Yes' or 'No.'

As you know, that isn't the most productive as far as PAL sessions go, but he seemed to understand the material fine, so I figured I couldn't force him to start talking. And then, in the fourth session when the students had an exam the next week, I made a PowerPoint Jeopardy game with questions from everything we had gone over in

the sessions and in the lecture. I put the first question up there and he clapped his hands to answer, and got it right. I was thinking, "Wow! That was the first time I've ever heard him speak."

"It really solidified for me the importance of including a variety of activities."

He answered the majority of the questions and really just came alive. The students were split up into teams, and I had one person on each team be the team captain. Even if he was the only one coming up with the answer, at least he was discussing it with his teammates before the team captain answered. At that point though, I was just so grateful that he was participating at all that I was okay with letting him dominate the show.

He was joking around after that, and I guess the different kind of activity was really what he needed. I think he felt comfortable and more confident answering things with a

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quick sentence or a vocab term rather than the long paragraph explanations that we'd been doing on our worksheets previously.

After that, he actually continued to be pretty active in the sessions. It really solidified for me the importance of including a variety of activities because not all students like the same things.

-JEANNA

"For the first few semesters of PAL, students would ask me questions about their homework, and I'd say, "Well, I can't answer that question." So then they'd find some other question really similar to it in their book. I hadn't looked at it, and I didn't I have any idea off the top of my head on how to do it – it was dumb of me to try and answer things like that. The most I could do if they asked me a question was to try. If I didn't know how to do it, I would say, "Okay, I'll look at this more and we'll talk about it next week." By then, it would be mostly irrelevant because they had to turn in their homework the next day.

So then, I actually started creating my worksheets after looking at their homework and picking out questions that weren't on it, but were very similar. Then, I never really had an issue with the after-class questions anymore.

I think last semester, somebody asked me a question after PAL and I had no idea how to do it by just glancing. I told him I would look at it that day and email him. I did, and I think it really helped in answering his question. It was a hard problem, and he wouldn't have been able to complete his homework without some help on it. I looked at the problem,

figured out how to do it and then prompted him with a few steps and asked a question in my email: “Do you know what to do next?” He responded asking, “Is this what I do?” He was right.

That was a good way to avoid being on the spot but I can’t get in the habit of that either, because then I’d be sending students emails all the time.

-SHANNON

“In one semester, a TA would grade the students’ essays using a list of comments where each comment had a coordinating number. He would write down either the canned comment or just the number and then give it back to the student. So students would get feedback like “sentence structure” or “supports the argument,” but they wouldn’t get feedback on how different arguments worked or didn’t work. I couldn’t believe this until the students actually showed me their essays. I thought, “This is just a nightmare. How can anyone learn like this?”

So, I took this TA’s weak point and turned it into something that I could work with. If the students are bringing in their essays and are really confused, this would be a good opportunity. In the end, I had students work through their essays one-on-one with each other, and have them figure out what they thought the TA was trying to say with each comment. How could they improve based on that? Not only was it helpful for their essays, but it also helped them work around the instructor’s method and adapt to the situation.

-JEFF

"There are always students who want you to tell them the answers ... and that always got on my nerves."

"There are always students who want you to tell them the answers. They'll get mad at you if you don't tell them, and that always got on my nerves. After a while, I changed some things in my sessions so it wouldn't happen so often. I had the groups put their answers on the

board for each question. Then the whole class would go through the problem together, and they'd pick which solutions on the board were right. So I would never tell them what was right; they had to decide.

-MICHELLE

"I had a voluntary session of PAL, and I was really pleased with my turn out. I'd been having between 14 and 20 students. I thought, "This is great! It's a big group, and I want them to have fun and not feel like I'm giving them a worksheet every week." So I made this game of Tic-Tac-Toe, which had nine questions and Tic-Tac-Toe boards with little flip tabs, so the groups would know if they got the answer right and could X or O their spot.

The students were in groups of four, two to a team. But there was only one group that half-played, out of five or six groups! None of them wanted to play a game; they just wanted to solve the problems. I would ask, "Did you guys finish that problem?"

"Yeah, we're doing the next one now."

“Okay, are you playing Tic-Tac-Toe? Are you marking the squares off?”

“No, we just want to do the problems.”

So I learned very quickly that in mandatory PAL sessions, like College Algebra, you had to make it fun for students to want to keep coming – especially for the students who fully understood the material. With voluntary PAL, the students come because they want to be there, because they want to practice problems and to questions; you don’t need a game for them. They liked doing a worksheet every week. They liked the repetition. If I changed it and put single problems on the board, they would ask me for more. I decided to just give them a worksheet every week because that’s what they were looking for.

I don’t know if that was just my one experience with voluntary PAL or if it’s consistent across the board, but I would not try to play a game again, even Jeopardy. I’ve also planned a game, but had too few students come, so it didn’t work.

Either way, the lesson learned is that there’s a big difference between mandatory and voluntary PAL, and it affects how you structure your session. Be prepared to be flexible with the number of students that arrive. You may get there and say, “This is a big number, let’s do groups,” or get there and say, “Hey, there’s not very many people today. Let’s work on our own like it’s a test and see how far we can get. Once you’re stuck, we can discuss them all.” You have to really be ready to adjust.

-ALICIA

"I used a Jeopardy review game every semester. Instead of creating it electronically, I just made a sheet of questions and handed that out to the students. The questions were in random order. Then I put the categories on the board; they didn't know which category corresponded to what question, so they couldn't do them ahead of time. Students would pick a box and I would say, "Okay, that corresponds to number 12."

I liked using Jeopardy because the students got competitive, so there was motivation to try other than just to learn. It always worked except for the last time I did it because the students were really into just doing problems. They wanted to learn, period. It wasn't like, "Oh, this will be fun AND I'll do math!" They just wanted to do well in the class. I don't know what the difference between the other classes was but they were like, "Can we just do the problems on the sheet and skip the game?" I said, "Okay, let's do it." So we did that instead, and it was great. I don't know what that was about; I think they were just a really motivated class.

-MICHELLE

"In the sociology lecture, the students were going over what deviance means. I split the students into two groups of five – fairly large. Originally they had smaller groups, but a couple people were skeptical. They felt larger groups were more comfortable. I told them to go out and perform a deviant act, but that they weren't allowed to say anything about what they were doing. Their job was to observe how others perceived their act. I gave them 10-15 minutes, and then they had to come back to report to the class afterwards.

One group had no idea what to do, so they sat in a circle in the middle of the bike path. Then, for whatever reason, they decided to do the crab walk. They kept their formation of the circle and, as people walked by, they followed them crab walking! These random observers were just staring at them because it was such an absurd sight. Then, they decided to just line up at the end of the bridge and stare at each person that walked by.

Recounting the stories was great; it was fun to hear them. We laughed, and we discussed how this activity was relevant to the lecture on how people exercise social control. I think it was a fun activity for them, and it was effective in getting the point across. I noticed that before these deviance trials, the groups weren't very cohesive, but when they came back, they were joking together and seemed to get a long really well.

I try to do as many activities as possible. For certain courses, though, it's really difficult to do them when they're strictly based on lectures and facts. I felt that sociology was a subject where the concepts could be applied to the outside world. I'm facilitating history now, and it's a bit more difficult. We do incorporate activities once in a while, but most of the time students want worksheets and discussions about what's been said in lecture.

-SOO

"When Mary told me she was going to observe my session, I just decided to go above and beyond what I normally do. I do not recommend this to any facilitator! Don't ever try to do more than

you would usually do in a session, even if your boss is coming to observe you: it's going to flop! I mean, your students are going to think, "What's going on? We never do this much work..." and you're not going to be mentally prepared to take on that much.

So I had this huge elaborate plan where I was going to show YouTube videos to the students to show the different kinds of arguments in a speech – logos, ethos, and pathos. It turned out that it was a really good activity, but just not in that much scope. The first video was the Sarah McLachlan animal rights video. It was an example of pathos, and I was going to have the students guess that. I started playing the video, and I saw Mary in the corner of the room just silently freaking out – covering her face and making these expressions. I had no idea how to read that! I kept thinking, "Am I not supposed to show YouTube videos?" I couldn't understand where the reaction was coming from, so I shut that one off really quickly as soon as the students guessed it.

I thought that I should just quickly go through the rest of them, so I explained the videos to the students more than I needed to. I thought maybe Mary just didn't like the use of videos. I showed the next one, and it was an Obama clip, and Mary was nodding, looking very approving. Then I had no idea what was going on. Another piece of advice: Don't look at the person who is observing you.

As I had the students working on something else, I went back to talk to her for a minute. She said, "I just hate that animal rights commercial!" I was like, "Ohhh, that's why you were throwing a fit in the corner!" It would've been great to know. So,

lesson learned. Mary just observed me again last week and I think I did much better this time!

-AMANDA

"This might just be specific to my group of international students, but when I would play games that had long directions and lots of steps, I would have to walk them through it step by step. They were more focused on trying to understand the game instead of trying to understand the concepts. Then I started doing more simple games like matching cards. I had a set of 15 sentences broken apart, and they had to match the cards up. They really got into that and were competitive about it.

"[The students] were more focused on trying to understand the game instead of trying to understand the concepts."

I also realized that, as I was playing games with them or doing different activities, a lot of students wouldn't participate as much because they were trying to write it all down. I started putting all the answers on a separate handout or on the back of a Bingo sheet. I would have a guide of what each answer was when they lifted the page up. They were appreciative of that so they could focus on what they were doing and also study it later. It was a more efficient way to do things.

-BETH

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"I currently use a lot of worksheets because, when I give out informal surveys throughout the semester asking the students what they want to get out of PAL, I always get votes for more worksheets. But then, I also get students who say worksheets are not all that fun. So, what to do? I think if you're in a really academically charged class, you need to do high-intensity, content-oriented material the whole way through. That's what the anthropology course was.

Now I'm facilitating political science; it's a way easier course and students are asking for more games. I only have one real game that I've done before because I've never had to do them in previous semesters; it's always been worksheets, worksheets, worksheets. I need to think of a new game...that's where I was going with that.

-HARRISON

What do you think?

- What engages your students?
- How can you assess what's working for them?
- In what ways can you accommodate a variety of learning styles and groups that move at different paces?
- What fundamental program goals guide your flexibility when adapting to your students?

Chapter 10: **PAL in Action**

■ After hearing the stories of so many facilitators, it's clear that conducting a PAL session is not something you can learn to do from a "how-to" guide. As you read in Chapter 8, situations come up that take you by surprise, and your best choice is to take what you know and roll with it.

■ There are recommended ways to approach troublesome students and a fine line between acting as a tutor and a facilitator. How you handle those situations when they're staring you in the face depends on the context and how you've adapted to your class.

■ Looking for some Dos and Don'ts in your PAL sessions? This storybook doesn't fit that format. With so many different variables at play in your sessions, there are no black-and-white rules or solutions. But we do believe in learning through others to prepare you for experiences of all sorts.

■ The following stories demonstrate what facilitators have done in their own sessions. Some things work, some things flop – and then you start preparing for next week.

-Lana

“ My very first session, I was so nervous. I had never done anything like this. I felt really awkward just sitting up at the front of the classroom when I got there; I just wanted

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to get started! So I started class five minutes early. Worst. Decision. Ever! It was literally the worst mistake I made in PAL.

I introduced myself, asked if the students knew what PAL was, explained it and got all that out of the way. Then, five to ten more students came! They trickled in after my introduction, so none of them knew who I was, what I knew about math, what PAL is, what they're expected to do: nothing. They asked me about things like that every week. I missed the original building block day, and I really regretted that.

I made sure never to start early from then on. It's inconsiderate to the students because they're not late. It's you starting early – then they kind of don't like you already! I was just so nervous. Just breathe and hold out. Maybe, don't arrive that early, so you don't have to feel them staring at you!

-MICHELLE

"I've used this activity on the first day both semesters that I've facilitated. I think it's a great activity to get the light bulbs to go on for students (I stole this so I can't take credit for it). I give each student two Post-it notes, they write their names on them, and they go to the wall. I say, "Reach as high as you can without jumping and put your Post-it note there." So they all do it and look around as if to say, "What's going on?" Then I say, "Now take your other Post-it note and put it even higher." They always find out that they can! Then I say to them, "Well, what does this have to do with goal-setting?" That's where the light bulb turns on, and we have a discussion about setting goals and going beyond them.

I have the students actually set goals for themselves – things they want to accomplish by the end of the semester, and it doesn't necessarily have to be about PAL. It's about what they want to do while they're in college. One of the goals was to visit the writing center and get an A on a big paper. Another was to do more of the readings for all of their classes, things like that. It's fun, it's interactive and they learn a lot from it.

Plus, it really gets them talking with each other. The first semester that I did it, I had students add a step to demonstrate what PAL does to help you with your goals. I said, "Now, help one person get their Post-it note even higher." They would take the smallest person and pick them up. There's that little illustration of the mice standing on each others' shoulders, that's kind of like what PAL is. As a group, you can do even more to exceed your goals. I think that really resounds with them.

-AMANDA

"I've done tons of icebreakers. Two Truths and a Lie – everyone does that, and I didn't feel like that was original at all. But there was one that I learned a long time ago where everyone stands up in a circle. I would clap my hands, for instance, and then the person next to me would have to say, "Stomp your feet." As they say, "Stomp your feet," they really have to be clapping their hands; they have to copy my action while saying something else. The next person in line would have to stomp their feet, but say something different. It was confusing because you were doing something that you weren't saying, but when you got it, it was really funny.

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Afterwards, we went around and said names while doing the same kind of thing. Everyone saw an action with a face. It was goofy because so many people messed up and if you did, you had to scream something obnoxious like, “I FORGOT ONE!” It was good for an icebreaker because it was goofy and everyone wanted to do it. If you messed up, you weren’t embarrassed because you got to yell something. People almost wanted to mess up!

I always like to come up with icebreakers that are

“The most important thing with icebreakers is to be creative, even if you go online and look things up.”

creative because everybody tends to do the same ones: talk to a partner, ask them where they’re from, find out an interest of theirs and that’s it. It’s repetitive and a lot of students probably aren’t paying attention. If you do something new though, it’s going to be more entertaining and fun. I think the most important thing with the icebreakers is to be creative,

even if you go online and look up things. Any activities where students have to interact and have more fun with it – things that are not so “teacher-student” centered – are enjoyable.

-MANDY

“This semester I did an icebreaker where I took note cards and wrote down a famous person on each of them. I took double-sided tape and taped them on the backs of my students. The class went around and asked ‘yes’ or ‘no’ questions to figure out the person on their back. Two people would stand, turn around

so they could look at each others' cards, and then ask, for example, "Is this person in politics?" Yes or no? I did it too and had a great time.

I got to know their names and made a connection with everyone. Also, it helped the students get to know each other, which is important because they would be working in groups all semester. Plus, they were a little tense – they needed to loosen up a bit, and I'm still working on that. That game helped though.

-NIKETA

"On the first day of class, the students haven't learned much yet since they've only had one lecture, so we usually have a lot of time for an icebreaker. I'll make a worksheet that's a grid – four squares by four squares – and hand them out to the students. They look at it and they're very confused because it's a blank sheet. Then I explain to them that we're going to sit in a big circle – if the tables allow it – and go around the room and introduce ourselves. We say our name, major, year in school, and then either something fun we did over winter break or in the summer, depending on the semester.

When they are going around the room introducing themselves, students are responsible for writing down each person's name as they say it. For example, if I were to go first, they would right down my name when I'm saying, "I'm Lauren. I'm a junior ...". By the time we get a round the circle, all their squares should be filled in excluding their own name. I have a ball that we throw back and forth, and I start with it. Before I throw the ball to someone though, I have to say their name. I have to know their name. I throw it to them, and then they

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would have to say someone else's name. As soon as they touch the ball, you're allowed to cross them off of your Name Bingo sheet.

The students like it because it's an icebreaker they don't expect. When you get three in a row and you need that fourth one, you have to really guess who it is, say the name and hope you're right. It's also nice to follow up with review Bingo on the geometry topics that they learn in the first lecture. It's Matho, my math version of bingo. It's the exact same grid on the other side of the paper. I give them 15 answers that they can place wherever they want and in the free space, they draw something they like about math. I give them the problems and if they get the problem right, the answer will be on the grid and they can mark it off.

-LAUREN

"Animal Noises is an icebreaker that I used on the first day of PAL. I picked about three different barnyard animals with fairly distinct noises, like a cow, a cat and a frog. I wrote them out on notecards and had about three in each group.

After we'd gone through the PAL introduction and the class introduction – names, where students are from, majors – I had them all get up and clear the desks away. We sat down in a circle, and I gave everyone a notecard. They weren't allowed to tell anyone else what it said. I said, "Look at your card. Think about the animal and the sound it makes. Now, close your eyes and when I count to three, you need to start making the sound of your animal. You have to listen to sounds other people are

making around you, and you're going to match yourselves with other people according to your animal."

They had to make the sound while listening for other people making a similar sound. When I first explained the icebreaker I just remember the LOOK that the students gave me. I think one even said, "Are you serious?" I'm like, "Yes, I'm dead serious! We're doing this." At first it was all awkward laughter, but they all knew that I meant it.

They started the activity, and it was great to see these students who have had no contact with each other blindly wandering around the classroom trying to find each other. I thought it was a really good icebreaker activity because it made each person put themselves out there. It was good for bonding; I think that them feeling humiliated together helped them bond in their group. I had them all introduce themselves further to each other and said, "Okay, these are the people you will be working with for the remainder of today's session."

-SOO

"I use this activity as an icebreaker on the first day to find out more about the students. In the past, I've had students in PAL sessions who just don't want to say anything; they're very shy. So I figure bribing them with a little candy can go a long way.

*"I figure bribing them
with a little candy can
go a long way."*

I start out with a bag of M&Ms, and I pass it around the room. I say, "Take as many as you want." There are always way too many M&Ms for the number of students, so students usually

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end up with a pile on their desk. Then I write on the board that the different colors correspond to different questions that students then have to answer about themselves. For instance, if you get a blue M&M, you have to name one place that you'd like to travel. If you get a red one, you have to name one movie that you really liked – things like that, different hobbies and such.

I didn't use it this semester, and I wish I had. I feel like the eating aspect, combined with students laughing at themselves when they realize that they have 25 M&Ms, kind of makes things comfortable right from the start. You start off in a joking, friendly atmosphere.

At first, students like the fact that there is candy, of course. But then, it becomes just a different way to find something out about your classmates – maybe something that you actually care about. I've had students figure out that they were on rival track teams in high school and competed against each other in the same event, at the same tournament.

I also do it to remember some things about the students. I can remember, "Oh, she's the person that has a fake front tooth." That's a real example too; you couldn't even tell! It's easier to remember names when there's some weird fact to go along with it.

-JEANNA

"I typically use "Would You Rather" as an icebreaker for the students to get more comfortable with each other and with me. Then we jump into what we're actually supposed to be doing, which is math. So, depending on how many students I have, I'll go on the Internet and search "Would You Rather" questions

and get enough so each student can have their own. I'll use it as my attendance.

I'll call off somebody's name and ask them a "Would You Rather" question. All the students get really engaged because they're funny questions – everybody wants to hear what the student would rather do. So they're listening both to the student's name and the answer; they get familiar with each other in the process. There's a lot of joking around with it too, because with some of the questions, you have NO idea which one you would rather do, like "Would you rather eat a bar of soap or drink a bottle of dishwashing liquid?" I mean, both of them are terrible! Which one would you rather do? So the students debate about it a little bit. It creates a more fun atmosphere than just jumping right into math.

-SHANNON

"Capture the Flag is a game that most everybody is familiar with, but the way I implement it is a little different. There are two teams. You can pick different teams in the Big 10 for example. I do the Minnesota Gophers versus the Wisconsin Badgers. Of course, no one wants to be the Badgers – but I digress.

Each team has its home base and then there are stations in between the two bases. You can have as many as you want – I think I had three stations between the bases. The teams work around in a circle starting from their home bases, so the whole room is set up in an oval. Let's say you're on the Gophers team. You first go to Station 1, then 2, then 3 and then you come to the Badgers' home base. Then you work around the other three

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stations that you haven't been to yet and finally end up back at your home base where you complete the game.

At each base or station, I have a different problem for the team to solve. If they solve it correctly, they move onto the next station. When they get to the other team's base – the Badgers, in our example – they take the Badger's flag. They have to continue answering questions at the remaining three stations and then a final problem at their own home base to successfully steal the flag.

I play with groups of three that move together through the bases. That way, everyone is on the same page and if they don't understand a problem, they can ask someone. When they reach their home base, they can go help others on their larger team – other Gophers for example. I never gave thought to a relay system, but that could be something to explore in the future.

I just made the game up when I was at home watching football. I'm like "Oh, we could play football in the classroom but modify it to be capture the flag." It's really active, and the student participation is really high. The students really enjoy that competition.

-JERED

"Word Scramble or Sentence Matching is the game where I have students match the word to its definition, or just main sentences broken up. I print the game in two columns on a page, so the first half of the sentence is in the left column and the rest of the sentence is in the other column. Then I cut them apart. I put the

students into groups and have each group try to organize the sets.

There are quite a few sets, probably 20-25, so it's a lot of work. When I played this in my session the groups got stuck. I pointed out wrong answers so they could try again. Then I took note of when they really couldn't get any further and let them each group send one person over to another group to ask for help. They had fun with that because they were running around, saying, "Hey, do you have this one?" It was great that they were using each other as resources, and since they were competing, they'd run over and joke with each other saying things like, "You can't have that answer! We're not telling you!" But, then they would anyways.

The activity was hard enough that they could learn from it, but it was structured so they could have fun too. I played music in that session as well, which was something we had talked about in our team meetings. The idea was that music would change the atmosphere of the room, and I really think it helped that time. It gave the session a more casual atmosphere and allowed the students to have more fun.

-BETH

"In the middle of the semester, I played a very simple game with my students that took about 5 minutes. You pick a partner, lock up your arms with your back to another person's back, and you start sitting on the floor. Without any help and only using your legs, you have to stand up. After you're successful, you find another pair and do the same thing with four people, so it's like

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a square. Then you have to do it with eight people, and then finally in the whole group of 16 people.

One group of four and one group of eight had difficulty standing up. You know, people all have different physical abilities. As a facilitator, I had to recognize that, let them pass and keep moving because it's a game. When they did it as a

"When they did [the activity] as a class, I saw leaders emerge."

class, I saw leaders emerge. I saw people organizing. Instead of people standing up one by one trying to drag other up, they stood up all together.

They were happy that they'd been successful. I think from that week on, the session was very successful as a whole; they were much more interactive with each other.

-ALEX

"I try to play games every other week. On the off weeks, I do problems on the board or worksheets, just to mix things up. Games are fun, but sometimes students don't learn as much from them because you're having too much fun. They're definitely more appropriate in review settings, too.

Towards the end of the semester I play a board game with the students called Race to Mathemagical Mountain. They have little animals as game pieces and they race around a pi-shaped board answering questions relating to the chapter they're learning. I usually use the logarithm chapter because it has easier problems to move around the board. Also, in the spring semester, I like to take my students outside when it gets nice.

Having a board game and all the pieces in a little box makes it easier to get out of the classroom.

I also like playing music in the background to lighten up the atmosphere. When I do this during games, students communicate more; they don't even realize they're talking about math. So instead of having awkward silences, you have groups

"Games bring the fun back, which [students] haven't had in a classroom in quite a while."

of six or eight around a game board; they're sharing thoughts about math, doing math problems and even when the conversations get off topic, it's usually not to the extent that I have to stop them because I know they're still doing the math. I can observe that just by walking around. It's easier for them to work

with one another when there is a game bringing them together.

I think what students like is that it allows them to almost be back in elementary and middle school again. Games bring the fun back, which they haven't had in a classroom in quite a while. In high school, I didn't have much fun in the classroom and in college, especially – you sit in lectures all day. So by playing games, the students have fun but they're doing what they're supposed to be doing at the college level.

-LAUREN

"I run a session for Chemistry 1021 which is Introduction to Chemistry here, but there's also a pre-introductory class which is 1015. Students either take that or just test right into 1021 on their placement exams. In the first few weeks of Chem 1021 then, the

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first couple chapters are all what you would call review chapters. Students should know the material going in, but some of them need extra help; others fly right through it.

In one of the first sessions, there was a mix of people who had taken Chem 1015 and had the information fresh in their head, and other people who hadn't taken a chemistry class since high school. They did well enough to pass the test, but that's never a good measure. When we were going through the worksheets, some students had no idea what a unit conversion problem looked like whereas other students would be like, "Oh yeah, I just did this last semester. No problem." It's hard to find that group cohesion when some people are flying through and some people are still stuck on problem one.

It was pretty evident which students could do it and which ones couldn't, so I tried to pair them up. While we were doing introductions, one of my students asked if we could share everyone's background in chemistry and I thought, "That's a great idea!" I had everyone go around and talk about the last time they had a chemistry class and that really opened up discussion. Sometimes if you're in a group situation and someone is always dragging, it's easy to think, "Ugh, why don't you get it? Didn't you do the homework?" But if the students all realize it in context – "Oh, she hasn't had chemistry in so many years" – then it makes the group's work a little easier.

I remembered being in that session and thinking, "Ohhh, crap. What am I going to do?" In the end though, it ended up being okay. Good session, moving onto the next one.

-MELISSA

"The vocab race was a test review. I had terms and definitions on individual pieces of paper, and made two sets of each. The terms were taped to the board and the definitions were on the table at the front of the room. The class was divided into two teams and when I said, "Go," the first person from each team would run up, grab a definition off the table and match it to a term on the chalkboard. Once they were done, the next person on the team could go. If they were stuck, they could put the definition back and pick another one.

Sometimes I felt the students were really lethargic because my session was fairly early. This activity was good because it got them moving around. You could tell that their energy levels perked up and as a result, they were more alert afterwards when we continued the review. Also, it instilled some friendly competition. They were joking around and egging each other on like, "I'm going to beat you!" and "Oh no, you're not!"

-SOO

"I used the Balloon Castle activity about the sixth week of the semester. My PAL session was a required session so I knew who to expect. I divided them into four or five groups of three or four people each. I gave the students about 75 large balloons and maybe two yards of scotch tape. I told them, "You have about 15 minutes to build a balloon castle. The group with the tallest castle will get candy as a prize."

Because I left a lot of room in the instructions, there was a lot of creativity put into it. I saw people struggle, and through the struggling and competitiveness, I saw interactions and

bonding happening. The students eventually became friends out of that activity. I also saw different personalities emerge that I hadn't seen while doing a worksheet or going through problems. As I mentioned, some people were competitive, some people didn't care; some people just wanted to have fun.

At the end, people don't usually get the result they expect. People who think they will win might be over ambitious and cause their balloon castle to fall. It has to stand by itself. I ended up giving everybody candy and asked them the question: "What did you learn from this activity?" I just wanted to get them to think about why they were doing this. Why are they in this PAL program? It's not just for academics. People did form study groups outside of PAL from the session, and that's good. Some said it was fun. Some said it was frustrating that they didn't get where they wanted with it.

Then after going through half of the circle, I asked, "What did you notice about the people you work with and yourself?" Then they talked about personal characteristics, group dynamics and what they learned about themselves. Then, of course, at the end, I had them break all the balloons just for fun. It was a small room – it was really loud!

I was a new PAL facilitator when I did this and I kind of planned things as we went along. I felt it was a good time in the semester to do the activity. People were in their comfort zones and not pushing themselves to interact with other people. Usually I plan sessions that are one hundred percent content; but if I feel something is needed for our session to take a break from the normal routine, then I'll do an activity. Like next week, I'm taking my students outside to do a PAL session. I came up with

the idea during my session and someone suggested we use chalk on the sidewalk. That sounds like a good idea!

-ALEX

“On my first day of facilitating political science, I made the mistake of mentioning that I had never taken this particular political science class. I had been a hobbyist in high school, but had never taken the university course. Plus, I planned the next session to be way too difficult, which just added to the students’ distrust in me as a facilitator. “He doesn’t know what he’s doing! He’s never taken this course! He’s made this way too hard!”

I would never, ever do that again. If you haven’t taken the course, don’t tell them that. Read up and stay ahead of them in the book. You don’t have to know everything. You should know all the material really well, but only up to the point just beyond what they’ve covered in class. Now, they’ll ask me a question and I can spit a good answer right back out because I’m prepared for that. Admitting that really added to the shaky foundation my sessions had in the beginning though. (laughs) I was stupid.

-HARRISON

“One thing I love doing is splitting up the class myself instead of letting the students choose their own groups because it forces them to get to know more people. It helps them a lot towards the end of the semester when people start missing class. Once the weather gets bad, people start getting sick and missing lectures. They’re able to go up to anyone in the PAL sessions for notes as

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opposed to knowing just one person. It also splits up the ability levels – some people are really good at math; some people aren't so great. Splitting it yourself pairs them together.

-LAUREN

"The best session I ever had was towards the end of the semester. We were finishing up the probability unit, which is one of the hardest units the students have in algebra. The students were getting to the point where they understood all the concepts, so we were going over really tough problems that had to do with counting cards and different keys words they had to know to do problems. It was right before a midterm. I would put up a problem on the board, and they would take five minutes to work in the groups to get the best answer they could. Then we'd come together as a class and I'd ask, "Okay, what's the first step?" Someone would raise their hand and tell me and then we'd go through the entire problem like that.

The best thing about that session was that there was really good conversation. No one was off topic or really behind. They had done all of their work to that point and were very much on task. If there were people who were having troubles, I would just ask them a question that would help them answer their own question in a way, which was really good. I know we're supposed to redirect questions in PAL, and it felt really good to know I could do that.

Everyone was talking, interacting, readily going to the board, and explaining answers to their peers. If there was a certain issue that we had – for instance, some people didn't understand conditional probability – we went over how to do

those more in-depth and looked for key words. We had a good time, a good time actually interacting.

It definitely made me realize what a good session is supposed to look like. I'd had a few good sessions with that group and was very happy, but by the end of it, it became THE PAL session – the way it should be run. I don't necessarily compare that session to the ones I have now, but it's definitely something to strive for – to get students to interact and be that social in a math-directed way.

-NIKETA

What do you think?

- When selecting activities and icebreakers that suit your class, what factors would you consider?
- Knowing all that you do about leading peer-group learning, what do you think are some general Dos and Dents in a session?
- At the end of the day, what is your vision of a really successful session?

Contributing Facilitators

University of Minnesota: Peer-Assisted Learning (PAL) program

Abby ('10), a double-major in nutrition science and biology, facilitated both introductory and intermediate chemistry courses during her time with the PAL program. She reflects that PAL taught her to listen and learn from students. Abby will begin the Ph.D. program at the University of Chicago in Molecular Metabolism and Nutrition in the fall of 2010.

Ahn ('11), a mathematics education major, is a facilitator for college algebra and probability. She hopes to obtain her teaching license and credits PAL for providing valuable career experience. "PAL allowed me to earn some experience in classroom which is helpful for my teaching career in the future," she says. "It taught me to how to set up lesson plans and activities for students."

Intermediate chemistry facilitator **Alex** ('11) is working towards his B.S. in Chemistry. He plans to attend medical school after completing his undergraduate degree. He reflects that working as a PAL facilitator has given him a new perspective. "PAL allows me to give back to my university community and to stand on the other side of the classroom to make learning more effective," he says. "It's been a maturing experience for me because I've learned how to communicate and work with different people."

Mathematics major, **Alicia** ('10), was right at home facilitating algebra, calculus and short calculus. She obtained her B.S. in Mathematics and plans to continue her education towards a teaching license in mathematics secondary education. "PAL

allowed me to practice leading a group (class) and developed my skills in asking directed questions to help students understand and figure out the solution,” she says.

For **Amanda** ('12), an English major, the PAL experience was a fundamental factor in her future career plans, among other things. “PAL is one of the most academically challenging and rewarding experiences I’ve had because it developed and sharpened all of my skills--professional and academic,” she says. “In addition, I developed a new interest in the field of education that has led me to a career path!” Amanda, who hopes to earn initial licensure in secondary education, facilitated a variety of courses including public speaking and multicultural literature.

Beth ('12), an architecture student, facilitated two design courses in the architecture department. After she obtains her undergraduate degree, Beth plans to attend graduate school, become a licensed architect and work in sustainable design. She says that PAL was a positive experience for her because of her students. “Helping them with the material was a good review for me, but also the opinions and thoughts expressed by the students revealed many new perspectives that I had never thought of. PAL has been an opportunity for me to use what I have learned while building relationships with students that share my passion for architecture.”

After facilitating precalculus classes and graduating with a double-major in mathematics and statistics, **Dorothy** ('09) decided to join the Teach For America program, a choice that she says was influenced by her experience with PAL. “PAL allowed me to share my knowledge of mathematics and explore my interest in education.” Dorothy now hopes to achieve a Master's in Statistics and possibly return to teaching.

A chemistry major, **Erin** ('11) has facilitated three semesters of organic chemistry. After obtaining her undergraduate degree, she plans to earn her science teaching license and master's in education so she might continue teaching chemistry to high school students. "PAL taught me to help others help themselves by empowering them to answer their own questions," Erin says.

Introductory courses to anthropology and political science were facilitated by **Harrison** ('10), a graduate who earned his B.A. while double-majoring in psychology and anthropology. "PAL allowed me to explore a new perspective on teaching that my future students will be sure to benefit from," he says. Harrison hopes to attend graduate school for counseling psychology while continuing to teach martial arts on the side.

Jeanna ('11), a double-major in child psychology and elementary education, has facilitated introductory psychology courses as well as "Biogeography of the Global Garden." She also works as a PAL team leader. Reflecting on the PAL experience, she says, "PAL gave me opportunities to form relationships with great people, gain experience managing a classroom full of students, and improve my confidence with public speaking." Upon finishing her undergraduate studies, Jeanna plans to obtain her master's in education, teach elementary school for a few years, and then continue her education to become a professor.

Jeff ('10), a triple-major in computer science, history and Latin says, "PAL let me spend time talking about interesting subjects with interesting people. It was an extraordinary experience - I think there's a chance to build teams, even in large classes and schools, and I enjoyed trying to share that with others and learn with them at the same time. I got to work with exceptional people and gained a great deal of confidence in my own leadership as well as in my peers."

Jered ('10), a math major with an education emphasis, facilitated four semesters of math, both precalculus and calculus. He was also a PAL team leader. He says, "PAL taught me the essentials that any teacher needs to know before walking in the room to have a successful session -- lesson preparation, time allocation and management, varied activities for different learning styles and intelligences. The training prepares you somewhat for what you should expect before you walk into a classroom as a facilitator, but no words nor training can truly teach you different facilitating strategies that you learn 'on-the-job.'" Jered will attend graduate school to get his M.S. in Mathematics with an education emphasis.

Kelley ('10), a facilitator for the College Algebra and Probability course says, "PAL was a rewarding experience for me because it gave me the opportunity to interact with my peers in a classroom setting, while inspiring personal growth." A graduate with a degree in journalism and public relations, Kelley is currently employed as a publicist.

Lauren ('11), a mathematics major, is a facilitator for precalculus courses who is known for her use of games in the sessions. She is also a PAL team leader. "PAL allowed me to creatively teach students and realize that teaching is definitely for me," she says. "It helped me to figure out what I want to do with my life in addition to helping me realize tricks for planning lessons." Lauren plans to finish her undergraduate studies, earn her teaching license for grades 5-12, and obtain a master's degree in math education.

PAL was an important career experience for **Mandy** ('09), who earned a B.S. in Elementary Education. "PAL taught me how to facilitate a classroom, which begins with preparing before class,

having material for all learners, actively involving all students, working together, and making effective use of time management. PAL has given me the opportunity to run my very first classroom which is incredibly memorable and important, since someday I will be a teacher." A previous facilitator of College Algebra and Probability, Mandy is working towards her Master's degree and teaching license.

Introductory and intermediate chemistry facilitator **Melissa** ('10) obtained her B.S. in Biochemistry. She will attend the Medical College of Wisconsin in the fall of 2010. She cites her students' changing attitudes as a high point of her work in the PAL program. "PAL was a wonderful experience for me because I was able to bond with my students," she says. "I watched their progress throughout the semester, especially as they started to enjoy chemistry, even though it was sometimes despised because of its difficulty."

Michelle ('11) facilitated precalculus with the PAL program. A biomedical engineering student, she hopes to work as an engineer at a medical device company after graduation. "PAL taught me to be confident that I can do the things I set out to do," she says.

Niketa ('12) says, "PAL has taught me how to become a better public speaker and have more confidence in myself. It truly has been a very enlightening experience." Niketa, a facilitator of College Algebra and Probability, is a biomedical engineering major with future plans for medical school.

A long-time facilitator, **Shannon** ('10) worked with the College Algebra and Probability course for six semesters. The 2010 graduate, who studied public relations and business

management, says, "PAL allowed me to explore how I work best while leading a group of my peers. The challenges I faced and overcame will be indescribably useful as I progress in the PR field." Shannon hopes to return to school and get a master's degree within the next 5 years, but is working in her field until then.

As a sociology of law major with a focus on criminology and deviance, **Soo** ('11) facilitated both sociology and history courses. She says: "PAL was a learning experience for me because it challenged me to think of how to adapt my own learning and teaching styles so that I could communicate better with others." After graduation, Soo hopes to either get her master's degree in sociology or law.